1987 Cosmic Overture

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How to Find Shelter

CO-01

???: *breathing* Take a deep breath, and relax.

???: This is my debut. I can't fail, not now. I have to do this for Mr. and Mrs. Kozlov and everyone in the circus. I must make them proud.

???: Mrs. Kozlov told me that I must guide the air through my body until it finds its balance.

???: Left, right. Good. Now, wave to the audience and say hello.

???: Oh, no!

???: I can do this. I'm almost there.

Steady yourself. Find your footing on a strand-thin wire.

Is it even there?

???: I can have this handled. First, I need to ...

???: I ...

???: There's no absolute direction up there. Up or down depends on the reference you choose.

???: I think she has the right to know what the "Storm" really is.

???: We will still need to cross the year 1999.

???: Alia. Come home.

???: Kiperina.

???: Vitals are stable. Biometrics returning to normal.

Medical Ward, Cosmodrome

The Laplace researcher still hasn't shaken off the weariness of her journey. The medic examines her closely, weighing her emotions as she explains the current situation.

Medical Staff Member: I'd heard you'd already left. Never thought you'd be back so quickly.

Medical Staff Member: It's obvious you care about them. So, I'm sure you know what to do when they wake up, Ms. Pointer.

Pointer gives a nod, her eyes fixed, scanning the blinking screens beside the bed.

Medical Staff Member: She hasn't suffered any serious trauma. All that Ms. Kiperina here needs is rest.

Medical Staff Member: But considering her condition, I recommend she stays here a few days longer for observation.

Pointer doesn't respond. After a long silence, she speaks.

Pointer: Thank you. What's the status of the others?

Medical Staff Member: Ms. Hissabeth is fine. She was awake earlier, for a few minutes anyway.

Medical Staff Member: She signed a donor card. Managed to get all her other siblings to sign it too. Not sure what we'd even do with them.

Medical Staff Member: That gentleman and that little salamander guy did the same thing when they woke up.

Medical Staff Member: Anyway, it's no cause for concern. I've seen my share of lunatics just like them. The real problem is determining treatment. There are so many details to pay attention to when dealing with these special patients: the dosage, their drug resistance ... And I'm not a vet, you know. I had to seek out some professional consultation.

Medical Staff Member: No offense, but I'm glad you weren't part of this ... attempt; otherwise, I might have had to face all of this by myself.

Pointer faces away from the bed and looks the staff member straight in the eye.

Pointer: I may not have approved of their taking on this project, but I'm still on the team.

Pointer: *sigh* If only the Foundation could devise regulations sufficient to control our staff's recklessness with their own lives.

Medical Staff Member: Hmm. Maybe they should consider controlling access to Picrasma Candy?

Pointer: Ugh, forget that. Even I can't help exceeding the recommended dosage sometimes.

Medical Staff Member: I'll be reporting to the headquarters of the Rehab Center next month. I'll let you know their average dosage by then.

Medical Staff Member: Anyway, I need to write up a visitors' schedule. We have to make sure our patients get enough rest.

The second visitor proves just how necessary a proper schedule can be.

???: How's she doing? I just left the other ward and thought I might drop by.

The new voice is polite and warm but still startles them.

Pointer: Hello, Ms. Windsong.

Medical Staff Member: Her vitals have stabilized. We're monitoring her recovery, but the initial results are positive.

Medical Staff Member: We can't say precisely when she'll wake up, but it shouldn't take more than a week.

Windsong: Good to hear. I'll be by to visit them from time to time, following the schedule, of course. Let me know if it's too much trouble.

Medical Staff Member: You're welcome to drop by here anytime. The isolation room is soundproof, but do keep it down when you visit the other wards.

Windsong: Of course. I'm just worried about them, you know. Besides, Vila and Avgust have drowned me in letters asking about the project.

Windsong: More importantly, there's a bond between a teacher and her student.

Medical Staff Member: I understand. I'll check in on the others. If you need any help, press that button to call me.

Medical Staff Member: By the way, Ms. Pointer, Godspeed to you and your team!

Medical Staff Member: A bunch of lunatics working together to reach space. Pretty damn cool, I'd say.

It's an unexpected and unorthodox compliment. The surprise is written all over Pointer's face.

Windsong: Ditto.

Pointer: Are you being serious? Do you think it's possible we could succeed?

Windsong: Listen to yourself, "we." Weren't you quitting the team?

After a short silence, they decide not to answer either question.

Windsong takes the first step, and Pointer follows her into the hallway, pulling the door shut behind them.

Windsong: Your comment on Hissabeth's project, you said it was "unrealistic." I don't think you really meant that.

Windsong: But, even if you do, why not stay and give them a hand? Their latest ideas for the teleportation disk sound solid to me. This one failure shouldn't be enough to walk away.

Windsong: You've worked with Hissabeth long enough. I'm sure you'd already know if she's pursuing a fool's errand.

Pointer chooses silence again. But this time, Windsong presses her concern.

Windsong: So, what do you really think?

Pointer: My thoughts are unimportant. All attempts to talk them out of it have failed, and what's worse, the more forcefully I attempt to dissuade them, the more determined they become.

Windsong: Alright, so lay it on me: why are they doomed to fail?

Pointer: I see no reason to expend any energy explaining it.

Windsong gestures at the ward behind her.

Windsong: Whatever. I'll just have to make my own judgments on the matter.

Pointer: ...

Pointer: Hissabeth is an excellent researcher, sharp and decisive. On those merits alone, she's earned my trust.

Pointer: My analysis points to a dangerous level of uncertainty in this project. The price of failure, even optimistically, could be much worse than a few days in recovery. There could be more permanent injuries. They could even ...

Her shoulders shrink in, but her voice remains calm.

Pointer: My nature compels me to do whatever I can to reduce the danger to our staff, and I want to keep my friends alive.

Pointer: What does it matter if we make it into space and discover whether the "Storm" affects the whole universe?

Pointer: Say that we determine this phenomenon only affects Earth, then what? We can't leave. We don't have the technology to fly off somewhere else.

Pointer: And if instead we determine the "Storm" is indeed universal, and that it will inevitably swallow up the stars, well, then wouldn't it all be pointless?

Pointer: Either way, my calculations are clear: the answer is not worth our lives.

Windsong: That's how you feel, I get it, so why not tell them?

Pointer: I've been attempting to find the right time to say it.

The ley lines scholar shrugs. She has the answer she came for.

Windsong: Maybe so. Speaking of things to say, I've got some news, and I thought it was better you hear it from me.

Windsong: Laplace has decided to evacuate the spaceport. All staff on-site are to be relocated before the end of the month.

Pointer: Evacuate? Where to? There is critical equipment here that can't be moved in that time frame. Besides, this spaceport was a part of our active partnership with the local government.

She lifts her head, and Windsong doesn't shy away from her gaze.

Pointer: Ah, we're moving to our real branch in Plesetsk, aren't we? The one on the edge of the Arctic Circle that's proven immune to the "Storm."

Pointer: This is our "Storm" Emergency Plan!

Windsong: You've got it.

Windsong: All Laplace employees are to spend a week in the care center after reporting to Plesetsk. The local staff will be put on paid vacation as is usual.

They both know exactly when this "paid vacation" will come to an end.

Windsong: Hissabeth was also waiting for the right time, and I guess this is it.

Windsong: Sign this for her, will you? Don't worry. It's not a donor card.

A sheet of paper is held out to her.

Pointer: You're asking me to sign this so that my teammates can stay here and die in the "Storm"?

Windsong: I'm not asking. I'm only delivering it to you.

Windsong: But they know what they're doing here.

Windsong: That's why I want to help.

Pointer: I need some time. My analysis won't be objective right now.

Windsong: Sure. Just don't keep your teammates waiting. Our time is short.

Pointer: ...

She places the paper neatly into her pocket, then returns to the glass to watch over the sleeping girl in the hospital bed.

A few months ago, none of them could have imagined it would come to this.

The Voyagers

CO-02

Radio: "Not long ago, Voyager 2 successfully reached Uranus, marking the first-ever exploration of this planet in human history. It conducted an examination of Uranus's ring system as planned ..."

Radio: "After a temporary orbital adjustment caused by its earlier visit to Titan, Voyager 1 continues its journey towards the edge of the solar system ..."

Radio: "Their future ..."

Plesetsk Office, Cosmodrome

The staticky but steady voice of the news cuts out.

Hissabeth: We already know where they're going and what they're gonna do. Why are you wasting time on old news?

Hissabeth: As I recall, we've even got a photo from Voyager 1 taken in 1990. It's stored somewhere in the Laplace archives.

Pointer: That's correct. They even have the development reports from Setun and the work done on meteor burst communication tech.

Pointer: But none of the archives mention the whereabouts of the Golden Records, do they?

Pointer: So there is a chance we'll hear some new clue this time around, like "According to the sudden decrease in Voyager 1's mass, it's been speculated that the Golden Records were intercepted by an unknown entity ..."

Hissabeth: "Intercepted," you make it sound like it was stolen by aliens, or space pirates!

Pointer: A space pirate? I doubt they would have any interest in some ordinary records.

Pointer: Now why don't you get to the point? What's so urgent that you had to switch off the radio?

Hissabeth: Oh, I'm making a video. I didn't want the sound drowning out the recording.

Hissabeth: Should be quiet enough now.

April 1986, Plesetsk Cosmodrome

Hissabeth, Laplace Researcher.

So, why was I mad enough to join this project? Call it a matter of personal interest.

Правда?
"Really"?

Let me introduce myself in a little more detail, in case you're shocked when you get your first look at me.

Hallway, Cosmodrome

Snake I: **Are we there yet? Drats! This is no way to travel! Let me just slither please.**

Snake V: **We don't have a choice. We're stuck with this most unfortunate mode of transportation.**

Introducing two of the nine siblings of the Dubois family, always loudly at odds and proud of it.

Thanks to the cold weather, the others're still brumating, so they haven't yet tested my patience.

Footsteps grow nearer, prompting them to look around for their source.

Receptionist: Welcome. Let me walk you to your office.

Receptionist: Your ID card, please.

Snake I: **Hiss.**

Receptionist: Oh, my apologies!

My patience just ran out.

The snake twists its body away with agility, but not fast enough. It is forced to clamp its mouth shut.

Hissabeth: Thank you for showing me the way.

Hissabeth: Why don't we speed up a bit? This place feels as cold as a goddamn morgue. I can barely talk without shivering.

When we get to the office, I'll warn them not to scare our colleagues for the fourth time.

Receptionist: Of course. We'll ensure the heat is kept on 24/7 inside your office. Laplace never neglects the little details.

In truth, as a reptile enthusiast, she's just trying to hide the rudeness of her surprise at seeing the cute snakes.

Receptionist: Here we are. Go ahead and knock on the door. Ms. Pointer should be expecting you.

Receptionist: By the way, since you mentioned the cold weather, do you need a thermostat for your lovely pets?

Receptionist: We try our best to meet all of our researchers' needs.

Hissabeth: Oh, we're all good. My coat works as a kind of thermo-regulated insulator. It should be fine.

Receptionist: Understood. And please note that the spaceport here is just a part of our local research collaboration. Laplace's official branch in Plesetsk is actually further north, right on the edge of the Arctic Circle.

Receptionist: It has a strict security policy. So, you'll need to file an application before visiting. There's no guarantee it will be approved either.

Receptionist: Welcome to the Plesetsk Cosmodrome.

Just a few steps out, the receptionist turns back, drawn by a faint sound.

The little golden-scaled snake flicks its tongue at her, and—was that a wink?

Receptionist: Goodbye, little hissie.

The researcher disappears down the hall, and cheerful voices ring out again.

Snake I: **You know what, Two, I think the staff here are more accommodating than most types we meet.**

Hissabeth: Or, are you just being more of a jerk than usual?

Hissabeth: Now stay out of trouble, and don't call me by my number again.

Hissabeth: Just so you know, I'm perfectly willing to tie you up by the tails if I start hearing about any "missing lab rats."

The door swings open, preventing the escalation of their family feud.

Hissabeth: ...?

Pointer: I knew I heard someone talking behind the door. Glad my ears don't need tuning.

Pointer: Please, come in. Are you the new researcher on this project?

Hissabeth: You've got it. So, I take it you're one of my new colleagues?

Office, Cosmodrome

The new colleague's attitude seems cold to the touch.

But once she steps inside and takes in the whole setup, she realizes that details like that won't matter too much.

Hissabeth: Two devices, two chairs, and two standard-issue desks.

Hissabeth: Is it just the two of us?

Pointer: I expected you to be more rigorous as a fellow Laplace researcher! According to official records, we have a third researcher on the team, an attache from the local government. In theory anyway, no one has ever seen or heard of them. It's just a name on the noticeboard.

Pointer: However, if you insist on ignoring our esteemed coworker—who I mention out of deep respect for our local partners—then correct, it's just the two of us.

Pointer: So, what do you think of our setup? It's not so bad. At least, we're in full control of our budget.

Pointer: Although, I recommend setting those budget expectations low.

Hissabeth: Cool, cool. Everything's more or less as I expected—an undervalued project in extraordinary times.

Hissabeth: What kind of bizarre mind hatched up the idea of teleporting supplies directly into space?

Pointer: Do you believe our goals are unrealistic?

Hissabeth: Not at all. Only eclectic, let's say. And I've always been a fan of eclectic theories. They are often a stepping stone to true discovery.

Hissabeth: I'm certain that the combination of arcanum and science will one day make up the core of our civilization. We're not there yet, but ...

Pointer: It's only a matter of time. Perhaps this project will be the next leap forward.

Pointer: So far, the teleport disk we've developed is functional but unstable. It's a one-way ticket capable of travel only within a short distance. But if we can improve its range and stability, I calculate its value to society to be potentially earth-shaking.

Hissabeth: Looks like we'll make for quite a team.

She picks up the stack of files from the desk, clearing a small spot to lean against.

Hissabeth: But before that, we'll have to make sure our project isn't shut down before it can begin, which means we need to cook up something worthwhile to put in our report.

Pointer: To that end, I know you're an expert in aerospace materials. Are there any specific specimens you need? I'll do what I can to source them for you.

Pointer: Oh, but be quick. Our resource applications must be submitted today. The evaluation process and all other little details mean it will take some time to arrive.

Hissabeth: Let me see. Hmm, no, I don't have any particular needs for now. How do you feel about fish?

Even Pointer's keen analytical mind struggles to keep up with the rapid topic change.

She pauses a full three seconds before answering.

Pointer: They're fine, as are those pets you've got dangling in your hair.

Hissabeth: Cool. Looks like I've come to exactly the right place. No nosy layabouts around to moan about my hobbies.

Hissabeth: Speaking of those "pets," they're not really pets. I remember mentioning them in my profile. You didn't read it, hmm?

Hissabeth: "Whatever, so long as they can hold their own!" Then you threw the file into the trash. Am I right?

Pointer: It wasn't quite so dramatic, but yes. I briefly scanned it for your field of expertise and experience. Nothing else mattered to me.

Hissabeth: Still, you should get to know your new colleagues. I'm a Melusine. We have snakes for hair. So, they're not pets. They're my siblings.

Hissabeth: Technically, you've got yourself a grand total of nine new coworkers. Surprise!

Pointer: That is certainly new information. It's unfortunate that Laplace doesn't pay out their Sharpodonties by head.

Hissabeth: Maybe I can convince them to go in for every two heads?

Pointer: I wouldn't predict your chances to be high, but a larger food allowance seems appropriate, given your additional mouths to feed.

Hissabeth: Mind requesting me a corner office? I need a lot of space for my fish tank. Pets and plants help me cool off.

Pointer: Whatever you want, let's just finish the report as soon as possible. Then we can apply for additional office space—one room for each of us. Deal?

Hissabeth: Deal.

Agreement reached. Pointer lifts her right hand.

A snake stretches forward to gently tap her palm with its head.

Pointer: Nice working with you.

Public Radio Usage Log

小径

Public Radio Usage Log

> Public radio. Five minutes per person per day. Listen to whatever you want, but leave an update in the log.
>
> ...
>
> 12:05 Restored the frequency to normal and listened to Swan Lake.
>
> 18:05 Tuned to a foreign station. Adjusted the frequency to avoid interference.
>
> 03:05 Attempt 39, still no reply from the cosmic friend. Answer me ... answer me ...
>
> 12:05 Restored the frequency to normal and listened to Swan Lake.
>
> 18:05 Tuned to a foreign station. Adjusted the frequency to avoid interference.
>
> ...
>
> 03:05 Attempt 42, observed an unusual aurora. Must be the cosmic friend, she's responding.
>
> 12:05 Restored the frequency to normal and listened to Swan Lake. Wishful thinking aside, remember to reset the settings.
>
> 18:05 Tuned to a foreign station. Adjusted the frequency to avoid interference.
>
> ...
>
> 03:05 Attempt 73, The terns' migration route is different from last year. Is she affecting the magnetic field?
>
> 12:08 Plesetsk is not going buy a second radio. Break it again, and we'll bury you in the snow.
>
> 18:05 Tuned to a foreign station. Adjusted the frequency to avoid interference.
>
> ...
>
> 03:05 Attempt 106, the magnetic anomaly has reached the edge of the polar circle. I so want to meet her.
>
> 12:00 Off to intercept a cosmic idealist in Mirny, break his bones, and reclaim the radio.
>
> 18:00 I hope his imaginary cosmic friend is real. As if.

The Meaning of Meaning

CO-03

May 1987, Plesetsk Cosmodrome

Everything from there on went smoothly and according to schedule. It was a genuine pleasure working with Pointer.

Well, those first days at least.

Pointer: Hissabeth, did you go to that ley lines lecture yesterday?

Pointer: I couldn't make it. I've been reviewing this data for the last 10 hours.

Pointer: The model is a mess. Something's off. I can't isolate the issue. It could be the system compiler, or the incantation. Or, maybe we missed some characters when we transcoded it.

Hissabeth: Hmm? Oh, the lecture? Yeah, Windsong mentioned it when we met her at the canteen a few days ago. Hold on.

The chair swivels halfway, and Hissabeth stands, stretching before setting her bread aside.

A snake holding a data card slithers up to Pointer's feet.

Hissabeth: This is Hélène. She woke up just a while ago. Hélène, meet Pointer.

Hissabeth: We couldn't all attend the lecture, but I asked someone to take Hélène there to observe. Here are the notes.

Pointer: I still haven't stopped being amazed by your siblings' telepathic connection.

Pointer: I wonder if there is an arcane skill that might approximate the same effect. Imagine how much faster we'd be able to share information with it.

Hissabeth: It's got its advantages, if you're willing to accept eight different voices oscillating between a party and a brawl every day in your mind.

Hissabeth shrugs and scoops up the little snake.

It shoots up her sleeve, vanishing into her blue hair to rejoin her siblings.

Hissabeth: Hope you don't mind. She's been a bit shy ever since we were little.

Pointer: That won't be a problem. I'll get it back to you in a few days. I just want to check if the study of ley lines can help with our aeroshell's force analysis.

Hissabeth: Is that all? You could've left a message. No need to go out of your way.

Pointer: Well, and I needed someone to unload a bit on. It's been months since I submitted our resupply application, and there doesn't appear to be any progress.

Pointer: This slow starvation for all of us is a waste of effort. They should just cut the cord and scrap all these projects they feel "show no value in the short term."

Hissabeth: Look at the silver lining. We're sure to get our new offices.

Pointer: Office space, the one thing we have in abundance here.

She waves her arms in irritation before slipping back into her usual tone.

Pointer: *sigh* Anyway, how are things on your side? I'm free for the moment.

Hissabeth: I'm progressing just fine. Take a look.

She steps closer to the desk. Hissabeth shifts some space and lays out the blueprints.

Pointer: Excellent. Feel free to let me know if you require any help.

Pointer: You know, for all the time we've worked together, there are still many questions left unanswered between us. I'm curious: why did you choose this project?

The tenor of their conversation has changed since their first meeting. This isn't a test. It's genuine concern.

Time has built enough trust between them to ask.

Pointer: There are many other teams pursuing the "combination of arcanum and science." I think one of them is presently working on cleaning incantations and plant-related rituals.

Pointer: Why choose Plesetsk? Is it that you feel your expertise in material science will be of most benefit here? Or do you have a particular interest in the aerospace industry?

Pointer: Don't mistake my intentions. I'm happy you chose to join our little team. You've performed exceptionally well so far.

Hissabeth: If I had to put a finger on it, I'd say it was curiosity. I really want to know where those Golden Records will end up.

She rolls up the blueprint before settling into a relaxed posture.

Hissabeth: Remember what I told you about my parents? They were studying information technology at Laplace before the first "Storm" struck.

Hissabeth's mind has always jumped around, but now Pointer can keep up. She knows to wait for the point to come back around.

Hissabeth: I can't wrap my head around that stuff. My whole life has been a constant stream of information. You wouldn't believe how distracting it is to have eight voices in your brain, bothering you night and day.

Hissabeth: Still, all nine of us enjoyed reading. Whenever we found a particularly compelling article, we'd divide it up and each focus on a different part.

Hissabeth: We'd always have a huge brainstorm after we finished. It was a lot of fun actually. *sigh* I miss those times.

Hissabeth: I still remember the day that meteor fell to Earth.

Radio: "Our latest reports are that Voyager 1 has officially traveled the furthest through our solar system of any man-made spacecraft ..."

Radio: "Surpassing Pioneer 10 by a distance of approximately 69.419 astronomical units ..."

Hissabeth: I don't remember where I was or what I was doing, but I remember the broadcast was talking about the Voyager 1.

Hissabeth: And that all nine of us were staring at the twinkling dot on the screen.

Little Hissabeth: If the moon is almost 400,000 kilometers away from us, how much further away was this little rock from Earth when it started on its journey?

Little Hissabeth: Unbelievable ...

Невероятно?
"Unbelievable"?

Hissabeth: We never knew the stars above our heads could actually fall into our world.

Hissabeth: What was happening up there? For all our brainstorms, we never reached the solid conclusion.

Hissabeth: Where will Voyager 1 go? Who, if anyone, will find its Golden Records? When will the stars stop shining?

Hissabeth: Are there researchers out there just like us living on another planet, looking for the same answers?

Hissabeth: One little meteor brought us so many questions, and we could never leave a stone unturned.

Pointer: I see. That's why you joined this project, despite its lack of immediate contributions to society.

Hissabeth: Nonsense! Our work is critical to the future of aerospace engineering. We've got plenty of contributions to offer.

This time, she's the one holding up a hand, waiting for a high five.

Pointer: Was that an attempt to cheer me up? There's no need. I'm not easily discouraged.

Palm to palm, their hands meet for just a moment.

Pointer: Hmm. You've warmed up a bit.

Hissabeth: Yeah, thanks to the 24/7 heating, and because I keep all of us well fed.

Hissabeth: Speaking of, I'm headed to town to find a restaurant. Care to join me?

Hissabeth: There's some decent food in Plesetsk now, thanks to the new policies. Do you want anything in particular?

Pointer: Your call.

Back then, we never thought to ask why our supply application had been put on ice for so long.

May 1987, Plesetsk Cosmodrome

Hissabeth: They're terminating the project?!

The noise startles the snakes. One by one, they poke their heads out to join the shock.

Too bad the moment's already passed. Pointer doesn't even have time to snap a picture.

Laplace Researcher: I understand, ma'am, but you should know that our top priority after each "Storm" is to restore the Foundation and the LSCC to full function as soon as possible.

Laplace Researcher: With our current shortages of resources and manpower, that means cutting all non-essential projects.

Hissabeth: Non-essential? Then what is it that counts as "essential"? Who decided on our priority?!

Before the snakes can hiss again in protest, Pointer reaches out and grabs Hissabeth.

Pointer: Calm down, Hissabeth. I understand that Mr. Ludwig did his best to keep as many projects running in Plesetsk as he could. We couldn't have stayed here this long if it weren't for him.

Pointer: But he's only a branch leader. He doesn't get to make the top-level decisions.

Hissabeth: They act as if all of their essential and valuable consumer technology just popped up out of nowhere!

Hissabeth: To think that aerospace engineering has less to contribute than their other projects?! S**t! They wouldn't even have vegetable packets in their instant noodles without us!

Laplace Researcher: I'm sorry, but our decision is final.

Laplace Researcher: Please allow me to finish. As you can imagine, I have several other meetings lined up after this.

Pointer: Sure. Please continue.

Laplace Researcher: Madam Lucy has expressed that she is not in favor of this decision. To that end, she asked me to deliver a "lifeline" for your work here.

Laplace Researcher: As you know, our knowledge about the "Storm" remains extremely limited. Madam Lucy believes we could better manage our circumstances if we could observe it in greater detail, particularly its extent.

Laplace Researcher: She's seeking volunteers from Plesetsk for a project, one that aims to send a monitor into space in order to collect data as the "Storm" arrives.

Hissabeth & Pointer: ...!

Two completely different reactions.

Hissabeth: What about the other projects? Where will the researchers be assigned if their projects have all been terminated?

Pointer shoots her another look, trying to signal her. But Hissabeth either doesn't notice or doesn't care.

Laplace Researcher: Most will be reassigned to other teams. I'm afraid there isn't much manpower to spare on our work here.

Laplace Researcher: That's the deal. If you want to stay on this project, then this mission must become your full focus. On the bright side, you'll have full access to all the resources left in Plesetsk.

He makes a quick glance down the hallway to check no one else is around, then steps closer and lowers his voice.

Laplace Researcher: I believe you two to be the most talented researchers in Plesetsk, and I know you want to achieve something with your work here.

Laplace Researcher: Still, I think I should caution you against accepting this task. Sure, if you pull this off, you'd become a legend throughout our organization, but there's only so much value in fame and admiration.

Hissabeth: And what would happen if we were to fail?

Laplace Researcher: I'm afraid your best hope would be instant death, and it may be much worse than that. No one knows for certain what the "Storm" can do, after all.

Laplace Researcher: I'm not sure this is worth your lives.

Noticing another researcher approaching from the far end of the hall with luggage in hand, he steps back, readopting his cool professional tone.

Laplace Researcher: Alright, that's all. I just need you to confirm that you've been informed. You'll have 24 hours to respond to our request.

After receiving the official documents, Pointer and Hissabeth return to their office.

They say nothing for a long time. The weight of the decision before them deserves their silent consideration. Finishing her deliberations, Pointer clears the air.

Pointer: Hissabeth, I know you're a big supporter of Madam Lucy, but I'm sure you agree this mission is a statistical death sentence.

Pointer: If you're struggling for a way to say no, I'll ...

Her words don't seem to have any purchase on her fellow researcher. Hissabeth looks up at her with a puzzled expression.

Hissabeth: Sorry, what? Never mind. I've got good news.

Hissabeth: I just talked to Windsong. She's got a solution to one of our major issues.

Hissabeth waves a hand as she answers, continuing her work.

Pointer: Wait. Don't tell me you want to volunteer?

Hissabeth: Why shouldn't we? This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity.

Pointer: But have you even considered the risk we'd be taking? Like the liaison said.

Hissabeth: We'll have all the equipment we need, with a project that's progressing smoothly, working towards an achievable goal for the common good.

Hissabeth: It is almost like the universe is within our grasp. All we must do is make our teleport disk work.

Pointer: It's not that simple. We'd still need an astronaut capable of launching the monitor. Who could we find that would be capable of acclimatizing to a zero-gravity environment under high heat and pressure in such a short time?

Hissabeth: That's the good news! Windsong already found us an ideal candidate—an acrobat.

Hissabeth finishes her task and holds out the sheet to Pointer: a follow-up work schedule.

Hissabeth: Here, I made a list of issues we'll need to tackle. Of course, that's only assuming you'll accept Madam Lucy's mission too.

Hissabeth: I remember we talked about space exploration when I first arrived in Plesetsk. You said you wanted to know what's going on up there, too.

Hissabeth: So tell me, what price are you willing to pay for that answer?

???: Breathe. Let the air find its balance within.

???: Remember what Mr. Kozlov said: "You must never be afraid of falling." I just have to imagine myself floating in space.

???: That's right. I will not fall from the wire again.

The circus barker's introduction booms above the blinding lights, followed by a wave of cheers and applause.

Circus Barker: Ladies and gentlemen, introducing our fabulous wire dancer, the youngest acrobat of the Utrennyaya Circus—

Circus Barker: Kiperina!

Beautiful New Things

CO-04

June 1987, Utrennyaya Circus

Kiperina, Star Acrobat of the Utrennyaya Circus.

Why did I join this project? Well, I guess I'm trying to help in any way I can, like I always do.

The circus is a lot like outer space.

It is a performance that exists within an almost weightless world of imagination. Close to reality but, at the same time, unreachable.

I've come to love the life that Mr. and Mrs. Kozlov provided for us there, and I never thought it might end.

Circus Stage

Kiperina: Here I am, Ringmaster. How can I help you?

Mr. Kozlov brushes a little ash off his seat, but when he hears Kiperina's voice, he bolts up immediately.

Mr. Kozlov: Oh, Alia. No need to be so formal outside of work. Anyways, how is it you are feeling today?

Mr. Kozlov: I don't want you to be overwhelmed. Take time for a little rest. Old Kozlov can manage things from here.

Kiperina: Please, it was just a thoughtless accident, and I won't let it happen again, I promise!

Kiperina: I've fully recovered. I know you're worried about me, but just ask anyone and you'll know I'm not lying. Even Mrs. Kozlov agreed.

Kiperina: See. I can even put on my firework show again.

Light bursts out from her outstretched fingertip, briefly illuminating the space like it's midday.

Like a plant drawing in sunlight, absorbing it, storing it, and then releasing it again.

A beautiful, if useless, arcane skill.

Mr. Kozlov: Oh! More beautiful than ever! It seems you've mastered the techniques that Ms. Windsong taught you.

Mr. Kozlov: There's no doubt our Alia has a budding talent for these ley line things!

Kiperina: Please don't start that again. I already told Ms. Windsong that I had no plans to leave the circus.

Mr. Kozlov: I know, I know. Such a loyal star you are. Oh, but there's something I should tell you.

He clears his throat, trying to smooth over the sudden topic shift.

Mr. Kozlov: Ahem, um, it's ... we're going to hold a show up near Mirny. They say the night sky is beautiful that far north. Perhaps you might even see the aurora.

Kiperina: All of a sudden? But it's so far from here. Are we in trouble?

Mr. Kozlov: No, everything's fine. I-It's just ...

Mr. Kozlov wrings his hands. Subtlety is not his strong suit.

Mr. Kozlov: Actually, Alia, Ms. Windsong called me. A friend of hers would like to meet you in Mirny.

Mr. Kozlov: They work for an organization called Laplace. I made inquiries at the arcane market. They have a good reputation.

Mr. Kozlov: Someone even told me that they were related to the St. Pavlov Foundation—that big organization that recruits all kinds of arcanists.

Mr. Kozlov: We are old, Alia, but you, your life has just begun. If you were to join Laplace or the Foundation, you'd live a much better life than any you could have in our little circus.

Kiperina: Do you want me to leave?

Mr. Kozlov: No. No, Alia. We just want to let you have another try. There may be some training involved, but we will not force you to stay. You can quit anytime you like.

Mr. Kozlov: Natalya and I, we hope you will have a safe and happy life. After that last time when you fell from the wire, we-we just can't bear to—

Kiperina: Then I'll go, Mr. Kozlov, if that's what you want for me.

Sensing the compromise in the girl's words, the man sighs and pats her head with a broad, fatherly hand.

Mr. Kozlov: We don't want you to leave, Alia. But this is an opportunity for you to live in comfort and safety. You're just 15. We don't want you to have to learn what it feels like to scrounge for food in the freezing wild.

He leaves it there. Some memories aren't worth retelling—not to a child.

Mr. Kozlov: Let's just give it a try. What do you say? You will always be welcome to come back to the Utrennyaya when you want. We will never turn you away from your home.

Kiperina: I've always known that.

She smiles, but it's not enough to hide the quiet weight of her insecurity.

Mr. Kozlov: Ms. Windsong gave you her card, remember?

Kiperina: I forgot where I put it. I figured they wouldn't ever find a need for a living light bulb.

Mr. Kozlov: Alia ...

Kiperina: So, then have you already planned the route, Mr. Kozlov? Are we traveling overland? When do we set off? And what are we taking with us?

Kiperina: What's the weather like in Mirny? Should I pack some warmer clothes?

Kiperina: Oh, it's been a while since the last time we restocked the medical kit. I'll check it later. We need to prepare for the animals' transportation.

Mr. Kozlov: Of course, of course, it's all in hand already. Our Alia, always such a self-starter.

Muttering, Mr. Kozlov turns away. It sounds more like pride than complaint.

Mr. Kozlov: Laplace sets a very high standard for its staff! Our Alia could only have been chosen if she were very special. Just see how she pays attention to each little detail.

The clever girl waits until Mr. Kozlov has disappeared.

She rarely lies, so, on the rare occasion she needs to, no one ever suspects.

The card's still with her, tucked in the inside pocket of her coat.

She isn't sure yet whether she really wants to chase after a faraway, wider world.

Kiperina: Windsong. Ley Lines Scholar.

Kiperina: I still don't get it. What even is "The Study of Ley Lines"? Is it like Arcanist Engineering? Or Math? I've never seen or heard of anything like it.

Kiperina: If I start to study these ley lines, does that mean I'll have to leave Utrennyaya forever?

Kiperina: That I won't be with Mr. and Mrs. Kozlov and the circus anymore?

She's still waiting on an answer from her mind, her heart, somewhere. So for now, she'll go back to her room and sleep in it.

Circus Tent

Kiperina: Our circus's big top was decorated by Mrs. Kozlov. She said that she wanted it to reflect the beauty of the stars and the weightlessness of outer space.

Kiperina: Such a beautiful view. Will I ever be able to see it again if I leave here?

Kiperina: I suppose I must meet these Laplace people, if that is what my family wants me to do. This way, we'll all be able to live a better life, right?

She lets her eyes close, picturing tiny specks of light emerging from the velvet darkness behind her lids.

Kiperina: One star ... two stars ... Ursa Major—the Great Bear, and the Little Bear ...

Kiperina: Mirny ... I don't think we've ever been there before, but I feel like I already know what the stars look like from there. How strange.

Kiperina: I wonder if the stars ever wander away from the sky. Will they all disappear one day?

Kiperina: What are their dreams like?

She drifts off to sleep. Soon, she finds herself walking through Mirny, holding a sparkling star in her hand.

Mirny is a place in the far north where you can see the aurora. She hopes it's as beautiful as it is in her dream.

Красивая?
"Beautiful"?

Mirny Soldier I: Over there! Keep up! What the hell is that?!

???: ...

Mirny Soldier II: Damn, is that a bear? But it's so fast!

Mirny Soldier III: How did it get in here? I've never heard of any kind of critter around here that can pass through walls like that!

???: ...

Mirny Soldier II: I caught it! Over here! Help, quickly!

The sound of her pursuers fades into the distance.

She must escape the darkness around her and move toward the light.

Where there is light, there is life, and other voices.

Radio: "Voyager 2 has successfully repaired its imaging platform and will proceed according to its originally scheduled exploration of Uranus ..."

Radio: "Voyager 1 continues its journey to the edge of the solar system and beyond. According to our projections, it is expected to pass by Proxima Centauri in around 70,000 years ..."

Kiperina: Mmm.

A hand slips out from under the blanket, fumbling around until it finally finds the radio's switch.

Kiperina: The same strange dream again. It's gotten more and more detailed since we arrived in Mirny.

Kiperina: I need something to distract myself. Ms. Windsong and Mr. Kozlov made an appointment to meet next week. Until then, I should continue to prepare for our show.

Kiperina: Utrennyaya is making its debut in Mirny tonight. It's a new beginning.

She peeks her head out just a little, peering past the tent flap.

Across from their circus tent stands a small restaurant, and the distant sounds of conversation put her at ease. The streets of Mirny echo with the steady rhythm of patrolling boots.

She hasn't seen the aurora yet, but even so, the novelty of it all makes her heart race.

Kiperina: *deep breath* I just need to cheer up and do my best.

Kiperina: I guess it's also my debut in Mirny. And first impressions are everything.

Kiperina: Maybe Mr. and Mrs. Kozlov will change their minds if I can win over the audience.

She steps out of the tent, ready for her first performance in Mirny.

Circus Barker: Ladies and gentlemen, introducing our fabulous wire dancer, the youngest acrobat of the Utrennyaya Circus—

Circus Barker: Kiperina!

???: ...!

Right here.

Heading toward the light, she sees many creatures making noise.

The sounds seem to rise above her head. To see more clearly, she pushes through the crowd and looks up.

Cheers and shouts, applause and heartbeats—they circle the figure above like planetary rings.

Points of light burst around the figure's silhouette. A few of them feel familiar. These particles were born from the nebula of her home.

She looks around, smiling in the middle of the noise. Earth is such a lively and beautiful place.

Breathe deep. Leap onto the wire. Twist, raise a hand in salute, and then exhale.

The audience erupts into applause—a perfect score for her routine.

Kiperina: Will they let me stay if I keep giving perfect performances like this?

The doubts buried in her chest begin to stir.

On the wire, Kiperina looks back, only to realize there's no one ahead of her nor behind.

Should I move forward or back?

Instinctively, she clenches her fist and follows the cheers with her eyes.

From these heights, it's hard to recognize anyone.

There are no friendly faces, no family. She's alone on the wire.

And that's how it's supposed to be.

???: ...!

Just like her dream. A flickering star points the way forward.

Don't stand still too long. They all want you to move on. They all want to see how far you'll go.

She steadies herself to take another step.

Move forward.

The show is over, the audience gone. Mr. Kozlov packs away the stage props, his voice booming with pride.

Mr. Kozlov: Natalya and I were a little worried for you back there, but it seems our worrying was for nothing. The show was even better than we hoped.

Mr. Kozlov: You did such a good job, Alia. The audience was thrilled! I knew we came to the right place.

Mr. Kozlov: I'll ask Natalya to prepare us a proper banquet tonight, something to reward our darling Alia and celebrate your new job at Laplace.

Kiperina: We still don't know about that yet, but I'll try my best.

Mr. Kozlov: I know you can do anything once you make up your mind to do it. And now, I must go discuss tonight's food with Natalya.

He walks off, still rambling, with the props in hand. Kiperina looks around. The massive tent now holds just two small figures.

One is her, and the other is the girl from before.

Kiperina: ...

The girl seems lost in the performance. She stares up at the stage, her eyes just as bright as the star that guided her to the other side of the rope.

Kiperina: Perhaps she's taking a break? Or waiting for someone.

She knows that Utrennyaya never turns away lingering audience members, but talking to new people has never been her strength.

Still, the show reminded her—sometimes it's worth taking that step forward, even if you don't know what comes next.

She doesn't hesitate this time.

Kiperina: ... Hello?

A Score of Time

CO-05

Radio: "We believe Voyager 1 will continue to explore the galaxy on and on ..."

Radio: "Traveling into the depths of the universe, carrying with it humanity's spirit of exploration, it is likely to persist longer than life on Earth ..."

The radio catches her new friend's attention in an odd way. She's spent the past few days fascinated with the little musical box.

Until another voice cuts through the broadcast.

Kiperina: What will the weather be like tomorrow? Maybe we can take a longer walk if it's sunny.

Kiperina: You haven't seen the diamond mine here in Mirny, have you?

The girl shakes her head, sets the radio aside, and waits for Kiperina to speak.

Kiperina kneels down. Now, they're eye to eye.

Kiperina: Is anything coming back to you? I asked some people around about you, but no one had any clue.

Kiperina: Don't worry. Most of us in the circus were adopted by Mr. Kozlov, so he won't mind if you stay with us. He always gives a hand to those in need.

Kiperina: And I'm going to meet an extraordinary lady tomorrow. She knows a lot. Maybe she will know who you are.

???: ...

Kiperina is used to this kind of blank stare. She's seen it on the faces of children that were lost while they were at the circus—how Mrs. Kozlov had comforted them, and kept them entertained until the smiles returned to their faces.

She stands up, steps back, and reaches her hand toward the girl.

Kiperina: Hey, look at this.

A soft glow blooms at her fingertip, warming the tent with its light.

Kiperina: It's my arcane skill. It's not very useful, I know, but don't you think it's pretty?

Kiperina: People say it looks like the stars.

???: ... Mhm.

The tiny light served its purpose. She seems far more at ease now.

Kiperina: I could do it again if you like.

Kiperina: Let's try something. Can you spell your name?

The girl eyes the colorful, crooked row of blocks placed in front of her. She doesn't know anything about the writing of this planet, so there's no way to share her name or where she's from.

But this creature wants a name to communicate with her. She understands that much.

The blocks form a messy, colorful path. A logic forms in her mind.

Kiperina searches for something familiar among the colors.

Kiperina: Long journey ... traveler?

Kiperina: *sigh* Sounds like you just picked these words up from the radio.

???: ...

Kiperina: Did you go on a long journey to reach Mirny?

Kiperina: Hmm. How was it that Mr. Kozlov decided on our stage names? Give me a second.

Kiperina: "Long journey," we could call that a "voyage." That would make you, who traveled a long journey, a ...

Kiperina: Voyager.

Kiperina stretches out her hand and traces the imagined path of the Voyager probe.

The girl watches for a moment, then imitates the gesture.

Voyager: Kiperina.

She twists her finger and points to herself.

Voyager: Voyager.

Kiperina: Now that you have a stage name, you are now an official member of the Utrennyaya Circus.

Kiperina: Hmm?

Voyager spins herself toward the tent's entrance. A moment later, footsteps and a familiar, friendly voice arrive together.

Natalya Kozlov: Alia, where's that girl? The one who was staring at the animals before? I brought a bunny around for her.

Natalya Kozlov: I suppose I'll be looking after her now, because you're meeting those Laplace people tomorrow, right?

Natalya Kozlov: You need a rest, Alia. Now do as Mama Kozlov says: go have a nice meal at the restaurant in town and then straight to bed early.

Kiperina: Mrs. Kozlov, I don't need to ...

Natalya Kozlov: Hush, just go. I didn't cook anything for you tonight. We've already paid the restaurant.

Voyager's head twists, unsure of where to look between the door and her new friend, but in the end, she chooses the fuzzy rabbit.

The tent falls quiet again, leaving Kiperina alone, looking helpless.

Kiperina: ...

Kiperina: I'm not just a little kid that you need to take care of.

Kiperina: Fine. I'll go, and after that, I will train for another hour.

Kiperina: Yes, that's for the best.

Hissabeth: That's all. Thanks.

Restaurant, Town

She closes the menu and slides it across the counter.

Hissabeth: Sorry, it sometimes takes us a while to decide on an order. So, you were saying you found a strange girl here in Mirny, and then?

Hissabeth: Hold on! That special device you're holding. Did you get it from Windsong?

Kiperina: Yes. Before I came to Mirny, I fell from the wire during a show, and Ms. Windsong happened to be there.

Kiperina: I don't remember the details, but she said my arcane skill was able to protect me.

Kiperina: She helped me draw out the aura from around my body and analyzed how it worked. Though I didn't understand that part at all.

Kiperina: But the name of her theory is still clear in my mind—The Study of Ley Lines. She gave me this device before she left. She said it would make it easier to control my arcane skill.

Kiperina: Mr. Kozlov wants me to give it a try again, so I've decided to go see her tomorrow.

Hissabeth: Cool. She's a great researcher. The Study of Ley Lines is still highly theoretical, but as we say at Laplace, theory often lays the foundation for practice.

Hissabeth: If you do decide to join us, I'd be happy to write a reference letter for you.

Kiperina: You're a Laplace researcher?

Hissabeth: You didn't already guess? Hmm. My colleagues often say I dress, you know, like a mad scientist.

Kiperina: I guess it's that I never thought I would meet a scientist eating at a little restaurant like this.

Hissabeth: Oh, please, I'm sure you're aware that scientists are living things too. We need to eat just like everyone else.

A few little snakes poke out of Hissabeth's hair, nodding along with her laughter.

One tilts its head up, letting Kiperina stroke it. Its scales feel smooth and cold.

Hissabeth: Looks like you meant it when you said you're good with animals.

Kiperina: I spend a lot of time with them in the circus. I even helped raise one of our bear cubs.

Kiperina hadn't been in the restaurant long before Hissabeth walked in and sat right beside her.

One of the snakes takes the lead in inspecting Kiperina, who greets it kindly in return.

That's all it takes for the two to find common ground.

Hissabeth: You know you haven't answered my question yet. Why do you choose to be an acrobat?

Hissabeth: Don't you find it scary to walk on a wire all the way up in the air? I suppose it is a really cool job, though.

Kiperina: Well, it is cool, I have to admit. But what I really like about being up on the wire is that, when you look down, you get to see a view that no one else gets to in their daily life.

Kiperina: When I stand on the wire, the audience below look just like stars, and it feels like I'm floating in space with them.

Kiperina: Isn't that great? In that moment, I stop worrying about my performance and forget all expectations. I can just be in the moment, shining like a star.

Hissabeth: Oh, intriguing. You know, in a way, I came all the way out here because I had the same thought.

Hissabeth: I wanna work with the smartest minds in the world, whether humans or arcanists. They're also like the stars in a lot of ways, each one bound to go down in history.

Hissabeth: And I'm trying to find out what really exists beyond the limits of the sky.

Kiperina: Do all your siblings share the same feeling? They're such neat little snakes. Oh, it looks like they have fallen asleep.

Hissabeth: We've always been on the same page when it comes to these things.

Hissabeth turns her head. Kiperina notices her pupils narrowing to a slit.

Hissabeth: Your arcane skill is exactly as I expected.

Hissabeth: It captures photons from the aurora and stores them as latent energy; then, when it's deployed, it appears to form a kind of prismatic plasma barrier.

Kiperina: Wh-What?

Hissabeth: I'll explain next time. It's complicated. It could take hours to get it into your head.

Hissabeth: Still, it is most obvious to me that you are exactly the person we want for this opportunity. What do you say? Will you give it a try?

Kiperina: ...?

Hissabeth: An opportunity to reach the stars.

Kiperina: ...!

Kiperina: You mean you're the colleague Ms. Windsong mentioned? The one who invited me to Mirny?

Kiperina: I should've known. Was this a test? I thought you were a friend I could talk to.

Hissabeth: A "friend"? Superbe, that's the best compliment I've received in months.

Hissabeth: Relax, this wasn't a test at all. We just happen to share the same taste in food.

Hissabeth: But I do hope you'll consider our offer seriously, in the spirit of the good time we had together.

Kiperina: Are you serious though? You really mean you want me to become an astronaut?

The invitation seems too far-fetched. Even in her wildest dreams, she could never have imagined it.

Hissabeth: Exactly.

But Hissabeth's response carries a rare weight, different from her usual casual tone.

Hissabeth: Don't rush to a decision. We can wait till tomorrow.

Hissabeth: In fact, the materials I've been expecting should arrive tomorrow as well. Maybe the delivery guy will bring you a small gift along the way.

Kiperina: You don't have to. Sorry, I didn't prepare any gifts.

Hissabeth: Don't be silly. It's just a friendly gesture. I believe you come from the same region, so I'll bet you two will get along quite famously. And he has an interesting nickname too. It was, umm, oh, right—

Name Day.

An Unexpected Encounter

小径

An Unexpected Encounter

> Surrounded by light but feeling no pain. The screams and footsteps around her are crystal clear.
>
> The first footsteps she hears are Kozlov and Natalya's. Their voices are more familiar than her own heartbeat.
>
> The clatter of goat hooves belongs to Elijah, still midway through his riding performance.
>
> The particularly light, quick footsteps are Fracios's, a habit left from his juggling practice.
>
> "Everyone stay calm. Her Arcanum has protected her very well." A strange voice. Must be an audience member stepping onto the stage. "Relax, girl. Try not to think too much. Just tell me, what you see right now?"

"This is unbelievable. I see a star, a shooting star is flying right toward me."

The stranger crouches beside her. The light dims just a little. "I'm going to use Ley Lines to dissolve your Arcanum. Stay relaxed. Talk to me about anything. What hobbies do you have?"

"Maybe they're not really hobbies, but ... I like to listen to the radio and weather reports. I also like exploring strange places. To keep from getting lost, I memorize all the unusual-looking trees and rocks along the way ... That star is still twinkling. That's not normal, right?"

"Don't worry. Maybe everything today happened just so you could meet that star. Let's keep talking. Would you like to study Ley Lines with me? You have a real talent, I'm sure of it ..."

The Great Utrennyaya Circus

小径

The Great Utrennyaya Circus

We have the best stage on Earth, each show as unique as a flake of snow.

We bring the most spirited performances in the world.

Elijah can turn any animal into the finest steed alive.

Fracios's performances will make you laugh until you cry.

And Kiperina, our tiny and adorable aerialist, walks on a wire so thin no one can even see it.

Ringmaster Kozlov has folded his entire life's reputation into this little tent.

From now until next month, this new world welcomes you!

What's Worse than the Journey · 1/2

CO-06

Ship models made of bone, delicate painted eggs, rusted parts, and yellowed scraps of draft paper.

Old pieces hastily thrown together somehow form an unexpected harmony.

Storeroom, Foundation Branch

Name Day: No. 136, from near the Kolyma Mountains.

Name Day: Tells the tale of the Polar Star icebreaker. The crew suffered some kind of mass hysteria. The same thing happened later in the Kola Peninsula.

He labels the notebook, writes down its number, and stores it away.

Name Day: Our destination is close to the Arctic Circle. With any luck, we should get a great view of the aurora.

June 1987, Far East Branch of St. Pavlov Foundation

Name Day, Investigator for St. Pavlov Foundation. Currently serving for Far East Branch.

Why did I join this project? Well, it is a job, and I like to do as I am told.

Name Day: Neva River, Lake Ladoga, Svir River, then Lake Onega ... It takes less time to travel by water. Maybe I can even buy a small gift along the way.

Name Day: What sort of specialties does Mirny have other than diamonds? Oh, maybe I can stop by Petrozavodsk on my way back.

He examines the map, plotting out a workable route.

Name Day: Looks like I'll have to walk the rest of the way after landing. Ah, Plesetsk, a place of boundless snow and not much else.

Fortunately, endless white fields of snow are something with which he has a wealth of experience.

Trying to reach the stars in order to monitor the "Storm" from space, huh? Sounds like a good gig, even if it does mean being stationed at the northernmost frozen tip of the world.

Maybe it will go nowhere, but what would we be without a little pioneering spirit?

In legends, a meteor may signal incoming disasters or foreshadow good fortune.

Like the "eternal soul," it all depends on what the viewer chooses to believe.

Вечный?
"Eternal"?

Little Name Day: Leningrad is just on the other side of this snowfield.

Little Name Day: I'll let that meteor guide my way.

In the end, he made it to Leningrad.

Name Day: The Foundation never gives me a break, which I guess makes me equal parts lucky and unlucky.

???: Mr. Name Day?

Name Day: Yep. Hold on!

As the door opens, a bundle of energetic fluff appears, orbiting at his teacher's feet as expected.

Vila: I heard you were leaving for the north on a new mission. Is that true?

Name Day: Just for an errand. The Far East Branch is short on staff right now, so I'm going all on my own.

Name Day: Ms. Windsong should be on a field trip there. Is there anything you'd like me to give her?

Avgust: Where is it? Is it north of Rayashki? Could I come visit there with Vila?

Children speak more directly, but the mention of a familiar place brings a few seconds of silence.

Name Day: Well, so long as you finish all your classes and get good grades, I'm certain you'll be able to go anywhere with Ms. Vila, as long as it is safe.

Name Day: But things could change. I can't promise anything. Except maybe a little souvenir when I get back. Now, Avgust, do you have anything you want me to give Ms. Windsong?

Avgust: Yes, and Vila does too. I've written lots and lots of things. Comrade Windsong can read them when no one is there to tell her a bedtime story.

Avgust: And this, from my tallest and most spirited sunflower guards!

He fumbles through his coat pocket and pulls out his most prized possession.

Avgust: You must not water them too much, and they should be placed somewhere under the sun.

Vila passes an envelope over, placing it next to the seeds.

Vila: I'd like this to be delivered to Ms. Windsong.

Vila: She said in the last letter that she had started to teach again, and it was more difficult than she remembered.

Vila: I wrote a little bit about my own experience teaching. Hope it helps.

Vila: And please talk to her if you have any ideas. You're so good with kids. Nina, Pyotr, and Pasono ask about you all the time, always wondering when you'll visit again.

Avgust: I didn't ask. I know how busy you are, Mr. Raccoon, and so is Vila. Every day, she's either painting something or talking to the white clothes.

Name Day: With any luck, I'll be free for a while after this mission. I'll come back and do some magic for you kids. What do you say?

He crouches and hooks his finger around the leaf of the wobbling sunflower.

Name Day: Deal?

Avgust: A good comrade must always keep his word!

The fuzzy hat bobs up and down twice—an earnest and sincere nod.

The conversation shifts back to the two adults.

Name Day: Sounds like you've been doing well recently. The Foundation's textbook is an easy read, but I really hadn't expected just how effortlessly you'd be able to make your lesson plans.

Vila: Lesson plans are nothing compared to field missions. Just keep this in mind during your errand: your safety is our first priority here.

Name Day: Of course, but the good news is I'm quite familiar with this era.

Though in this era, the city hasn't yet reverted to its old name—Saint Petersburg.

Talk like this always seems to circle back to that little town swallowed in snow.

But now's not the time for that.

Name Day: Um, anyway, I'll make sure Ms. Windsong receives Avgust's seeds and your letter.

Vila: Thanks a lot. I don't want to make our goodbyes here too long-winded. Just take care, especially since you're going to be all on your own.

Name Day: Well, I won't exactly be "all on my own."

Snowy Field

Han Zhang: Hey, so, any idea how far off this place is? I think we must be pretty close. I can almost see that unmistakable Laplace metal roof!

Han Zhang: I've actually got some business lined up in Mirny. Those diamonds of theirs are certain to fetch a tidy profit back in the East Branch.

Name Day: I should've never let you out. Can we make a deal? You stay quiet, and I'll get you safely to our destination. Then, you can say whatever you've got to say to whoever made the mistake of inviting you here.

Name Day: *sigh* You know you really, really, really like to talk? I'm beginning to understand why no one else would take this job!

Han Zhang: Whoever heard of a merchant who doesn't like to talk? Ha. Admit it, you'd be bored to tears if I were not here.

Han Zhang: ...?!

The chatty salamander is tucked under Name Day's coat, its muttering smothered along with it.

Name Day: Quiet.

Han Zhang: Bandits—in the Arctic Circle? That's new.

Nearby snowbanks serve perfectly as cover, shielding Name Day from view.

Robber I: Where is he? I saw someone coming this way.

Robber II: We can't let him get any further. There's some kind of military base up ahead. And it's heavily guarded.

Robber II: Think how far we've gone. We can't go home empty-handed. That arcane item they've got is probably worth a few Sharpodonties, don't you think?

Han Zhang: &%#*! (curses from the east) "Item." Hey! I'm a living, breathing creature!

Name Day: You don't need to yell at me. Say it to them if you like!

A branch heavy with snow snaps and is broken into a stick that fits his grip comfortably.

Han Zhang: What? Are you sure? Never mind. What should I yell?

Name Day: Anything. I just need you to draw their attention.

Name Day: I'm not letting them anywhere near Plesetsk.

Robber I: This way! I hear something. Keep up!

A dark shape juts out of the snow—the odd appearance of the strange metal vessel draws every eye.

Han Zhang: Errrr. Ro-Ro-Robbery! Hands up, and give me all your cash!

Name Day's blade lands right in time, stopping the hand reaching for the vessel.

Name Day: *Čабля.

Have You Heard?

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Have You Heard?

"That kid seems to have disappeared. You know where he went?"

"Who?"

"The talkative one. Obsessed with Roman myths."

"Are you describing yourself?"

"Name Day. I'm talking about Name Day."

"You were closer to him than I was. Why ask me?"

"The only thing I ever talked with him about was those myths."

"Huh, our conversations were usually limited to German folklore. He seems to always keep people at a distance."

"Nonsense. He hated German mythology."

"Stop projecting. As far as we talked it seemed like he loved German culture. We talked about it all the time."

Two Foundation staff glare at each other in the cafeteria, on the verge of fighting over a man they thought they knew, until a third person sits down between them.

"You're talking about Name Day? He took two months off. I think he's on vacation."

"That workaholic actually went on vacation? I thought his life was nothing but work and collecting trinkets."

"Where'd he go?"

"No idea. We only worked together on one mission, but he was a decent guy."

"Did he ever chat with you about anything else?"

"We talked about folk legends."

"Roman?"

"German?"

"Gothic."

What's Worse than the Journey · 2/2

CO-06

Name Day tosses aside his stick and scoops up a handful of snow.

The robbers' footprints trail away into the distance. If they had one redeeming trait, it was knowing when to cut their losses.

Han Zhang: What were you waiting for with that knife?

Name Day: Oh, well, it's more of a collectible than a weapon.

Name Day: But I guess you understand now why they sent me to escort you instead of hiding you in the back of some truck, huh?

Han Zhang: I didn't see a single truck heading for Plesetsk on our whole journey here. By the way, was that knife thingy part of your arcane skill? Why don't you just make a gun instead?

Han Zhang: Times have changed, friend. Blades are out of date. You should give yourself an upgrade and start blasting!

Name Day: Nah. I'd probably be serving with Zeno if I was any good with guns.

Name Day: Have you ever heard of that legendary pilot from Zeno, the Barents Witch?

Name Day: If you were really important, then you would get a guard like that. All that being a noisy little salamander gets you is a guy that can turn trash into knives.

Han Zhang: Ah! That's nearly the most useless arcane skill I've ever heard of.

Han Zhang: I say "nearly" because it's still better than mine. So, I'm not in a position to criticize.

Name Day: What does your arcane skill do?

The salamander's silhouette flickers, crumbling into a puff of ash, then, in the blink of an eye, reforms itself.

Han Zhang: That's it.

Name Day: It's certainly ... something.

The rest of the journey is at last blessedly quiet.

Their destination draws near. The outlines of buildings take shape, and someone is already waiting in the snow.

Name Day: Ms. Windsong.

The so-called cosmodrome isn't nearly as grand as imagined.

Surrounded by the vast expanse of white, people and buildings alike feel small.

Windsong: Hello, gentlemen.

Windsong: Welcome to Plesetsk.

The Wilds and the Garden

CO-07

Windsong: You arrived earlier than expected. Pointer and Hissabeth will be happy to know you got here safely.

Windsong: Oh, FYI, Pointer was the researcher who introduced me to Laplace. You might have met her before in Rayashki. She's occupied with a few important visitors right now. We'll talk to her later.

Windsong: As for Hissabeth, you can meet her in person and save me the trouble of an introduction.

She pushes open the door.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the building, Pointer enters through another door.

Pointer: Our appointment was set for an hour from now. You're a bit early, sir.

Pointer steps aside, motioning for the people hurrying behind her to go in first. She studies the quiet girl, not finding anything particularly unusual.

Mr. Kozlov: There wasn't much work to do today. And Alia always has everything prepared ahead of anything important. I-It's nothing to worry about.

Pointer: Please take a seat. Windsong and Hissabeth will join us later.

Pointer: If you have any questions, feel free to ask me.

Kiperina: Thank you, ma'am. Please call me Kiperina. I have something to ask you.

Kiperina is the first to speak, surprising Pointer. She adjusts her expression, adding a hint of warmth to her smile.

Pointer: That's fine with me, Ms. Kiperina. My name is Pointer. So, what would you like to know?

Kiperina: If I take the offer and complete all the required training, what will I get in return? Do you pay in ruble or something equivalent?

Kiperina: And I'd also like to know if my family will receive my pay in case anything happens to me.

Pointer looks up and examines the girl once more. She can read the worry in Mr. Kozlov's face, but she still can't quite place the look on hers.

Somewhere between courage and fear. Too fine a line for Pointer to draw.

Plants and machines crowd the limited space, struggling for a balance somewhere between jungle and office floor. It's warmer here than in the hallway outside.

Name Day glances sideways, but Windsong has no intention of speaking.

Name Day: Hello? Is anyone there?

Name Day: The materials you sent from the Far East Branch have arrived safely.

Name Day: Everything you asked for on your list is there. But you should check it over as soon as possible.

He scrounges around for a clear spot on the desk and pulls a metal vessel from his pocket,

revealing a little sleeping salamander roused from its slumber by a tap on the head that sends a puff of ash into the air.

Name Day: Hey. Wake up. You're at work.

Hissabeth emerges from behind the machinery and offers a brisk wave to Windsong.

Hissabeth: Windsong? Back from the mine already? Are you going to throw a welcome party for our new colleagues?

Windsong: The mine can wait, but I can't. Those materials are top priority.

Now Hissabeth turns her attention to the young man in front of her.

Hissabeth: Thanks. You might have heard of me. My name's Hissabeth.

Hissabeth: You've read our proposal, haven't you? It'd save me a lot of trouble if you had. I'll catch you up with Pointer as soon as she's available.

Name Day finds himself staring at the curious little snakes poking out, swearing he saw one flick its tongue.

There's no time to hesitate. He decides to follow proper etiquette—handshake, then introduction.

Name Day: Name Day, Foundation Investigator for the Far East Branch.

Name Day: Mind if I ask you a question?

Hissabeth: Go on. But this is an office, not an interrogation room.

She looks around with an airy glance and, spotting the extra object on the desk, gives the little salamander a second gentle rap on the head.

Name Day: Why did you ask me to smuggle in this runium?

Hissabeth: What?

Name Day: Don't get me wrong. I didn't report it. It's just ... it's odd. You didn't ask for much, just a few pieces.

Name Day: It is a rare resource, I grant you. But I think you could've gotten this amount with no trouble by submitting an application. All you'd need to do is wait for a few weeks.

Name Day: Was it really worth the risk?

Hissabeth: Yeah, because we don't have a few weeks to spare.

Windsong: Saving every bit of time we can is vital. It is as precious as this bag of sunflower seeds from a distant land. You don't find them often in these parts.

Windsong: Here.

She lifts her hand and tosses Hissabeth a small cloth bag.

Windsong: I've already taken my share. Why not plant some of these in the office?

Windsong: It won't take too much effort. If you're lucky, you'll get to see them turn their heads towards the light bulbs.

Hissabeth pulls out exactly what she was hoping for.

Rare arcanum energy, tossed carelessly into the air but caught with practiced ease.

Hissabeth: Actually, Mr. Name Day, you're the perfect man for this job. You knew what you were smuggling, you had the perfect excuse to come here, and you were kind enough to help. It was quite the effort to track you down, you know.

Hissabeth: So, how did the trip go? Any trouble?

Name Day: You bet there was. Though I'm still not sure what those bandits were after, the runium or our noisy "arcane item."

Hissabeth: There's a shortage of supplies everywhere nowadays. People take what they can, whether they need it or not.

Hissabeth: Even if they managed to take the cargo, it'd probably just end up in another branch of the Foundation or Laplace.

Hissabeth: Anyway, you saved us a lot of time and resources.

Name Day: Just bear in mind, this runium is not something that you can replace even with Sharpodonties.

Hissabeth: Thanks. We'll use it sparingly. Please send my gratitude to Ms. Vila.

Hissabeth: And one more thing.

Hissabeth: What would you say if I asked you to stay?

Hissabeth: Don't worry. I won't play the Windsong card. It's only a personal request.

Hissabeth: We could save a lot of time with our procedural work if we had a Foundation Investigator on the team.

Hissabeth: And it could be a great opportunity to earn a reputation. Imagine the prestige if the project ends up a success.

Name Day: ...

He swallows his words, not intending to explain his reason for being here.

Hissabeth's version works just fine—easy to understand, and not too personal.

Name Day: Are you making any progress?

Hissabeth: As much as we can, but we don't have a single Sharpodonty to our name, and this runium is the sum total of all the supplies we've received recently.

Hissabeth: They told us we could use all the resources left in Plesetsk, but that amounts to jack all. Thankfully, we still have half a rocket, fuel, and a launch button. Still, to make up for the supply shortage, we need additional manpower.

Hissabeth: Oh, but there's some good news: we don't have to worry about finding our astronaut. We already have a perfect candidate.

Pointer: We're in dire need of an astronaut.

Pointer: There isn't enough time for anyone to finish the full training course. No one would be able to acclimate to a zero-gravity environment in such a short time, not to mention the high pressure and heat.

Pointer: But you may be the exception, Ms. Kiperina. Your arcane skill may allow us to work a miracle.

Pointer: So, if you take the offer, we'll provide you with a salary and try to get you a permanent position here at Laplace.

Pointer: Hissabeth is already working on it. She has a contact in the Foundation who can help with the procedures.

Kiperina: Alright then. I have no more questions.

Pointer notes that, despite their thorough explanation, the girl seems no less worried.

Kiperina: But, just to be clear, I don't think my arcane skill is as useful as you believe. It only makes a little firework show.

Mr. Kozlov: Heh, she's being modest. You know how children are when they receive a compliment, but I tell you she is more than willing to take your offer. Please give her an opportunity. You'll see how reliable she is!

Mr. Kozlov: By the way, another little arcanist girl joined our circus recently. Do you think she could stay with you too?

Pointer: That's not really how this works. Not everyone's arcane skill works in the same manner.

Mr. Kozlov: But she would keep Alia company. Please, madam, Alia is still just a child who plays with dolls.

Kiperina: Mr. Kozlov, stop! I haven't played with dolls in ages!

Kiperina: I ... I'm already grown up!

Pointer: ...

Seeing emotion break through the girl's steady silence at last, Pointer feels she's reached the root of the issue.

Pointer: We'll take a look at what she can do. Would you be able to bring her here now?

Mr. Kozlov: Of ... of course. I'll be right back.

He bolts up and out of the office. In his wake, Kiperina hesitates, shifting in her seat, until at last sitting up straighter.

Pointer's smile fades. There's no need for social niceties in what comes next.

Pointer: Alright, we're finally alone. Now, how about you tell me what you're actually thinking?

Hissabeth: Our biggest issue remains unsolved, but I'm most certain we can resolve it.

Hissabeth: The entire project is a mixed bag right now, but I'd say more good than bad.

Hissabeth: If our little sleepyhead in that pod there can provide what we need, our situation should improve dramatically.

She tips the little vessel, giving the salamander a brief experience of zero gravity.

Han Zhang: I was dreaming of cutting a tree on the moon.

Han Zhang: *yawn* You'd better have a good reason to wake me up. I'm not your lackey. We made a deal, that's all. And I'm freaking tired after that trip!

Hissabeth: Yeah, and about that deal? I need something from you, now.

Hissabeth: This little pod of yours. It's electrically insulated, heat-resistant, and highly durable against arcane energy. In short: the perfect aerospace material.

Hissabeth: All I need is to sand off a bit of material from it. Don't worry. Just think of it as dental work.

Han Zhang: Wait, wait. You haven't paid for that yet.

Han Zhang: A deal is a deal.

She needs a moment to think but eventually lands on a solution.

She hooks a tiny badge the size of a fingernail onto the salamander's tail.

Hissabeth: Here's your ID card. Just to be clear, this is only for an internship. You'll need to actually work to earn yourself a permanent one.

Hissabeth: And don't do anything stupid. I vouched for you, and now both our necks are on the line.

Han Zhang: Oh, it does look good on me. I knew I belong with Laplace. *sigh* The engineers at the Foundation's East Branch are way too competitive for my liking.

Han Zhang: So, what else you need? I've brought some records about gunpowder-fueled flight, and a few books on Eastern alchemy. Though, I'm not sure you'd be able to read any of them.

As the little salamander chatters on, she flips over its vessel and inspects it thoroughly before pointing to the square markings on the vessel's base.

The others gather close, unable to resist their curiosity.

Hissabeth: What does this mean?

Han Zhang: Oh, that? You know, I got this pod from the Panjiayuan Antique Market. It's not a genuine antique, but the craftsmanship is quite excellent.

Han Zhang: These characters here mean "microwave safe." Funny enough, microwave ovens were not that popular when I got it.

Han Zhang: Speaking of Panjiayuan, you can't find a flea market as big or as fun anywhere else. If you're ever looking for antiques and collectibles, it should be your first stop.

Han Zhang: Humph, if you want to go take a look, I might just be nice for once and take you ...

Little salamander notices their eager eyes.

At last, a chance to show off its salesman charm—a moment it's determined to seize.

Hissabeth: No, thanks. Just making sure it doesn't mean "danger, explosive." I already learned that lesson from another escapade with an arcane invention.

She returns the dagger she'd borrowed—who knows when—and slips the vial of metal powder into her desk drawer.

Hissabeth: Alright. I've collected enough. You were so busy talking you didn't feel a thing, did you?

Hissabeth: Now, back to our visitor in the checkered pattern uniform, have you made a decision?

After a brief pause, the question Name Day asks switches the conversation to an entirely different track.

Name Day: What are you going to do with the little astronaut when the project's over?

Hissabeth: I'll submit her application to Laplace once she agrees to join us. It'd be great if you could help with her employment procedures.

Name Day: I mean, when are you going to tell her the real consequences of the "Storm"?

Hissabeth: Same as always, as soon as she gets a permanent position with Laplace.

Name Day glances at Windsong, thinking she might chime in—offer an explanation, at least. But she only nods.

That's just how it is. That little astronaut, whom they've never even met, will have to learn it too: That pale dome and those cold steel buildings can't protect everyone.

Soon, the rain will wash away all that's familiar to them. Again, and again.

Name Day: ...

Name Day: Alright, then I'll stay.

Pointer: You mean you really want to stay with the circus?

Kiperina doesn't have a straight answer.

Kiperina: I ... I meant that I'm willing to do whatever you need, but I don't think I want to do this permanently.

Kiperina: Since you say that you need my arcane skill for this project, I'm happy to help, though I don't really know if I can.

Pointer: I think you know why Mr. Kozlov brought you all this way.

Pointer: When was the last time you had a proper meal?

Kiperina: Well, we usually have stews, and sometimes Mr. Kozlov will find us some canned food if we're lucky.

Her rebuttal is soft and utterly unconvincing.

Pointer: And you still want to spend the rest of your life in that circus?

Kiperina: ...

A knock breaks the silence. Kiperina uses the moment to lift her head.

By the time she sits back down again, the light that had flickered in her eyes is gone.

Mr. Kozlov: This is her, the girl I talked about. She doesn't speak much, but I feel that she has a good character.

Voyager: ...

The girl casts a sweeping look across the room, pausing briefly on Pointer.

Mr. Kozlov: Don't be shy. You can sit next to Alia.

Mr. Kozlov: What were you talking about? I hope our Alia didn't cause any trouble, madam.

He steps into the room, noticing immediately that Kiperina is fixated on the parcel in his hands. It's filled with things he and Natalya packed—things they thought the girls might need.

Kiperina: Mr. Kozlov ...

Kiperina: Will I ever have the chance to return to Utrennyaya?

When We Move Forward · 1/2

CO-08

Kiperina: Will I ever have the chance to return to Utrennyaya?

Hissabeth pushes the door open just in time to catch this scene. She lingers nearby, curious, watching the girl receive her answer.

Mr. Kozlov: We can talk about that in the future.

Mr. Kozlov: Of course, we will keep in touch. You and Voyager can pay us a visit whenever you like.

Mr. Kozlov: The girl's called Voyager, madam. She's clever, quiet, doesn't eat much. You-You will take her in too, won't you?

Pointer doesn't object. She runs a brief analysis and concludes that the company of a peer could help ease the pressures of Kiperina's training.

After listening carefully, Mr. Kozlov pats Kiperina's shoulder.

Mr. Kozlov: I always hoped you would settle down and live a comfortable life. Promise me, you'll do your best, Alia.

Kiperina: Yes, Mr. Kozlov.

Hissabeth: Oh, you've finally reached an agreement. Cool, looks like I won't have to do any more explaining.

Hissabeth: If you're saying goodbye soon, maybe you ought to consider bringing her a parting gift. She looks like she could use one.

Name Day: Yeah, something to remind her of home.

Name Day picks up the thread without missing a beat.

Windsong steps forward just in time, joining Kiperina's side, and Hissabeth trails off.

Windsong: Or maybe you can offer a few words of encouragement? What do you say?

Mr. Kozlov spies Kiperina rubbing the device in her hands with her pinky—the one Windsong had lent her earlier. He knows her well enough to understand the meaning: nervous.

He has no idea about the device's exact value, but he's certain it's not something you'd easily find in a circus.

Mr. Kozlov: Right, right, a gift. I-I'll need some time to prepare it.

Mr. Kozlov: Let's make a deal, shall we? You'll get your gift next time you pay a visit to the Utrennyaya.

Mr. Kozlov: That way, you'll keep us in mind and come home again one day. I was worried you might not want to travel such a long way for us.

Kiperina: I will, Mr. Kozlov. I'll find my way back to Utrennyaya even if you've moved to the other end of the world.

She struggles to lift the parcel Mr. Kozlov gave her. Name Day quickly steps in to assist her in placing it on the table.

"Time flies." The thought pops into Mr. Kozlov's head, but what he says out loud has nothing to do with it.

Mr. Kozlov: Hahaha, that's my girl.

Mr. Kozlov: Remember what I said? Do the best that you can and have no regrets.

Mr. Kozlov: Natalya and I don't have to worry about you, do we?

Kiperina: No.

Kiperina: I'll give my best performance here, like I always did with Utrennyaya.

Almost like she's trying to convince herself, she nods twice in a row and makes a solemn promise in her most serious tone.

A question rises up in her, just below the surface. How can she be sure? She chooses not to ask.

/lo/ - The Spread of Enigmafication

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/lo/ - The Spread of Enigmafication

0001 Anonymous No.95025535 ▸
Just had a two-year project canceled. Soon I too will be able to hide out in my room all day playing Sudoku. Not sad about this at all.

0002 Anonymous No.95025586 ▸ >>95025620
I wouldn't start celebrating just yet. It looks like you're about to lose your vacation time since there's a shortage of staff everywhere.

0003 Anonymous No.95025620 ▸ >>95025867
>>95025586
What are they gonna do? It's not like a simple number theory major like me can contribute to rebuilding in the wake of the "Storm." Nothing's going to stop me from going on vacation, nothing!

0004 Anonymous No.95025631 ▸ >>95025718
Would you look at that? The Enigmafication is spreading nicely. Good. At this rate, I'll have the entire Laplace break room all to myself.

0005 Anonymous No.95025718 ▸ >>95025961
>>95025631
As more people start slacking off, supplies will be cut too. You might get to hog all the Daily Meals from all of Laplace, but that's probably the best you'll do.

0006 Anonymous No.95025867 ▸
>>95025620
You know, it'd be hilarious if a bunch of random numbers and formulas turned out to be the key to defeating the "Storm," and you got roped into nonstop 24/7 work trying to crack it, with Madam Lucy interrogating you three times a day about your progress.

0007 Anonymous No.95025961 ▸
>>95025718
That sounds absolutely disgusting. I need a nap just at the thought of that.

0008 Anonymous No.95026012 ▸
Oh, and as part of the "humanitarian" gesture, I'll make sure your voice gets added to the machine too.

0009 Anonymous No.95026078 ▸ >>95026278
Well isn't that something? There are still poor souls who didn't get a vacation even at a time like this, with all these non-essential projects getting cut?

0010 Anonymous No.95026278 ▸ >>95026293
>>95026078
There's plenty. Like John from the medical team, John from the mechanical engineering group, and John from materials science ... Basically, every non-theoretical department is pulling all-nighters to rebuild Laplace under Madam Lucy's brand of ruthless pragmatism.

0011 Anonymous No.95026293 ▸
>>95026278
It really makes you wonder if the "Storm" was part of a conspiracy by the Johns to steal funding from the rest of the teams and justify their overtime pay. Coincidence? I think not!

When We Move Forward · 2/2

CO-08

June 1987, Plesetsk Cosmodrome

Pointer: How do you feel? Intense nausea is common for the first few months of zero-g training.

Kiperina: *pant* I think I'm fine.

Kiperina: You're very kind to ask, ma'am.

Her first training session was rough and more than a little messy, causing her to throw up.

Pointer helped her to the infirmary. Once she could breathe again, she stammered out a request—just like the one she made today.

Kiperina: I'm ready for more.

Pointer: You're at this again? Hissabeth already checked your vitals and arcane skill test reports. Her conclusion was clear: You need to rest and recover before we begin again.

Pointer: If you push yourself too hard and become too sick to perform the mission, that won't help us either.

Kiperina: But I can do more. All I need is a bit more training. I need to perform flawlessly.

Pointer: We don't need "flawless," not at the cost of your health. We need "satisfies all requirements." Nothing more.

She adjusts her tone, searching her mind for something that might qualify as comfort or encouragement.

Pointer: You're already doing better than we anticipated.

She fears the words come out too flat, but Kiperina shakes her head sincerely.

Kiperina: Thank you. But I still haven't memorized the flight procedures, and I'm still struggling with my arcane skill.

Kiperina: Maybe I can ask Ms. Windsong to give me another ley lines lesson. That's not "pushing myself," is it?

Pointer: ...

Pointer: That's acceptable, but you will ensure you get a minimum of eight hours of sleep every day.

Pointer gives in. She too had once been hell-bent on proving herself.

Pointer: And promise me you'll eat well and never skip meals.

Kiperina: Yes, ma'am. Ms. Hissabeth said there would be a team-building dinner tonight. I'll attend it and train for another half an hour after we come back.

Pointer: No. That's not what I meant.

There are few tasks more difficult than instructing a child who is too mature for her own good.

Pointer: *sigh* Anyway, go change. We'll go together.

Of all the restaurants in Mirny, this one does the best business, thanks in no small part to Hissabeth.

With all those mouths to feed, food has always been a vital part of her lifestyle, one that she is only too eager to share with her team.

Plus, the tables here are big enough for everyone in their group to have a seat.

Hissabeth: We sat here when we first met, non?

Kiperina: I think so. This table seems a bit too small now.

Windsong: Well, there's strength in numbers.

Hissabeth: Yet everything now depends on our brave astronaut. How's your arcane skill training?

Kiperina: Not bad, I guess. Ms. Windsong is a wise teacher.

Windsong: Haha, I'm glad I've learned something from my experience with Vila. I hope you'll get to know her one day.

Hissabeth: You'll have plenty of time to make friends once you return from your mission.

Kiperina: Looking forward to it. But first I have to go back to the circus. I think Mr. Kozlov will have my gift prepared by then. I'm sure he will.

Kiperina: Though, he didn't come to see me and Voyager this week.

Name Day: He has a whole circus to run, and you're busy with training. It's hard to find a good time when you're both free.

Name Day: Perhaps he didn't want to make you homesick, but I'm sure he misses you a lot.

Name Day: Mirny isn't far from here. You should go back and visit sometime. No one will blame you if you take a break for a few hours.

Pointer: I am able to drive you to town, if you need.

Pointer: Just submit your schedule two days in advance. I will set some time aside for a short trip.

Kiperina: Thank you. But I think it'll have to wait until the project's over.

Kiperina: Mr. Kozlov said I would always be able to visit him in the future. Besides, he needs time to prepare the gift.

Not everyone is interested in the still distant future. Kiperina's friend, at least, is more focused on what's right in front of her.

She taps the edge of the small vessel, smiling at the crisp, metallic sound it makes.

Han Zhang: Err. Don't do that. The echo from that sound makes me dizzy.

Voyager: ...?

She pulls her hand back and watches until confirming the little creature is friendly.

Then she reaches out again, trying to figure out how to get along with it.

Kiperina: Voyager?

Kiperina: Don't get distracted. They've almost finished the food.

Name Day swaps the food around the table, pushing two still-full plates to the middle.

Cold scales press against Kiperina's wrist.

Snake I: **Feel like a drink? Here, we've got some hot milk or warm apple cider. Pick one.**

Dragging a cup behind it, the snake leaves splotches of spilled drink all across the table.

Kiperina: Milk will be fine. Thank you.

Kiperina passes another cup to Voyager. She mimics the others by lifting the cup, first in both hands and then just one.

Hissabeth: Let's have a toast, friends. To our new team, though no one knows for sure whether our project will succeed or is doomed to fail catastrophically.

Hissabeth: Together, we're working towards the future, cheers!

A friendly signal. A quiet promise of unity.

A turning point in any story or relationship, from a stranger to a colleague, and eventually—

Друг/Товарищ.
"Friend/Comrade."

All: Cheers!

Hissabeth: Having said that, the odds are in our favor. Even though Laplace is no longer in its prime, it still has the best technology and the finest scientists.

Windsong: The finest scientists? You mean us? I couldn't agree more. I've always believed that perseverance is the most basic fundamental quality that any researcher should possess.

Pointer: Perseverance ... There's only one thing that I think we should persevere with: our efforts to return to the future.

Name Day: Didn't know you Laplace researchers missed the good old days so much.

Pointer: Laugh if you want, but you can't deny that our era was better than this one.

Kiperina keens her ears in, trying to catch each word. The room is warm, and the conversation at their table easy and relaxed. The question she's been keeping down finally bubbles out of her mouth.

Kiperina: What was the future like?

Kiperina: I've read through the manual for temporary employees. The data we're going to collect may help people get back the things that they lost, right? From the futures that you've been to.

Kiperina: What's Leningrad like in 1999? Were there any circus shows in your era?

Kiperina: Does that mean everything was better than it is now? I have trouble imagining it. Were there sweets for everyone and stores that never ran out of food?

Windsong: ...

Windsong: Things were much better then, well, except for the study of ley lines. It was still struggling as a scientific pursuit, especially when it came to attracting new students. Though, even now its only student seems to lack much interest in it.

Kiperina: Th-That's not true! Sorry, I'm just having difficulty focusing on it with all the other demands on my time.

Name Day: It's okay. Ms. Windsong was only making a joke at the expense of her very overworked student.

Name Day: It's true things were nicer in the future. I do miss the sweets, and that the shops were never empty.

Every witness seems to offer her the same promise: it's worth it.

Life should move forward, not stay stuck in the past.

Kiperina: Amazing! I'm sure we'll make it back one day!

This time, she raises her cup first.

To Former Strangers

CO-09

1987, Plesetsk Cosmodrome
3 months before the "Storm"

Three, two, one, cut.

And just so we're clear, everything went well as usual.

The video in this disk, to put it simply, is too much for anyone to handle.

Guess what it's used for. Go on. Give me the most ridiculous answer you can think of.

A little tip: think like a modern person. The development of technology allows us to save a lot of things as digital data nowadays.

Yes, it's a last record. A video is much more convenient than sitting down with a pen.

She places the data card on the table. It immediately draws in all eyes.

Hissabeth: Data secured. Pointer, do you want me to add your part to the video now? Or maybe later?

Pointer: Preferably never. This whole "last record" thing is your passion. Besides, I know nothing about material sciences.

Hissabeth: But you spent so much time transcoding the incantation. You simply must show up in my video. Please, I insist.

Hissabeth: We're a team. We shouldn't miss anyone's perspective, non?

Pointer: Yes.

Even for her, long hours can wear things down. There's a trace of fatigue in her otherwise calm reply, a lag in her response.

Hissabeth: Superbe, then let's take a look at our work so far and learn from our mistakes, well, my mistakes.

Pointer and I had been working on the teleport disk at the Plesetsk Cosmodrome.

More specifically, our interim mission was to determine how to transport supplies to space stations and spacecraft using teleport incantations. The ultimate goal being to achieve stable, safe, and long-distance teleportation to outer space viable for living organisms.

The project had been going smoothly until we received some bad news.

Due to a policy change at Laplace, most projects in Plesetsk were being suspended.

Fortunately, the bad news was followed by a small amount of good. Madam Lucy said if we could send a monitor to space to collect data when the "Storm" arrived ...

We'd be allowed to continue with our project! It was a vital opportunity to make our contribution to deciphering the "Storm"!

There were only three major issues to solve: manpower, energy supply, and determination.

As you can see, the first two issues have been solved by our new members. Thank you all for your help.

Especially our brave little astronaut.

The plan is now simple. She'll fly into space, reach the required altitude, launch the monitor, and zero in on the correct coordinates, and then, she'll contact ground control to come home.

Her arcane skill will protect her from any possible danger caused by pressure or heat in the vacuum of space.

Then finally, she will activate the teleport disk, and we will activate our receiver on the ground.

Ta-da! Everyone will arrive in Laplace's Arctic Branch safe and sound to acclaim and accolades from all around the scientific world!

Well, that's a simple framework of the plan. But we still have tons of minor problems to tackle first.

Our top priority is improving the long-distance positioning accuracy of the teleport disk. We've already begun testing our latest prototypes.

Though the last test didn't end well.

We're still searching for the cause of that particular catastrophic error. But we won't let it stop us. This was no more than an inevitable roadblock, a small accident on the way to technological progress.

Pointer: Hissabeth, if we are going to have any chance of learning from our mistakes, we can't run away from our problems.

Alright, alright. That last test was a week ago.

Hissabeth: Same as the last time. Though we've made some improvements, we still need an intelligent creature to run the test.

Hissabeth: And I guess it'll be me again.

Name Day: Are you sure? Considering the danger and your value to the project, I think you ought to let me ...

Hissabeth: How can I ask anyone to try my invention if I wouldn't use it myself?

Hissabeth: Now, what are you waiting for? Get to the safe zone. Oh, and remember to secure the blast door.

Name Day: Ms. Kiperina asked about the test yesterday as she was feeding the fish.

Name Day: She said she's been able to control her power more now. You'd be much safer with her help.

Name Day: We're a team, right? We sink or swim together.

As the clock strikes the hour, a small figure peeks in through the door.

Kiperina: My training just finished. I hope I'm not late, Ms. Hissabeth.

Hissabeth: Well, we did have a pretty bad accident, but thanks to Kiperina's arcane skill, no one was too badly hurt. Windsong is one cool teacher, and that girl's a phenomenal student.

Hissabeth: The margin of error remained high, a significant problem for sure. But we'd learned our lesson after spending all that time recovering in the ward.

Hissabeth: That is, that we should prepare for the worst, so that those who survive will know what to do with, umm, our legacy.

Hissabeth: Our last record matters, my friend.

Snake I: **Two, I don't think that's what Pointer meant when she told us to "learn from our mistakes."**

Before Hissabeth can pinch its mouth shut, the little snake ducks back into her hair.

Pointer: ...

Pointer: Again, I emphasize that safety must come first in the lab. It is my first and most important protocol.

Pointer: Windsong and I left for all of ten minutes, and by the time we got back, each and every one of you ended up on death's door!

Pointer: And now I find out you've even petitioned for a postponed evacuation. This is getting ridiculous!

Hissabeth: You know how tight the schedule is now that the "Storm" Emergency Plan has been activated, don't you?

Hissabeth: The silver lining is that now we know that we have exactly three months. We can still optimize the procedure and improve the disk and ...

Pointer: Enough, Sylvie!

Pointer cuts her off. Her tone is serious.

Name Day: Oh, c'mon, friends. Can we just calm down and discuss our schedule over dinner?

Name Day: I believe Ms. Pointer was only trying to suggest a better plan.

Pointer: I am. I suggest we stop all work on this project immediately.

The young man is caught off balance, unable to find the words to ease the tension in the room.

Hissabeth: What? Why? The situation really isn't that dire.

Kiperina: Ms. Hissabeth is right. We shouldn't be discouraged over one accident, Ms. Pointer. The damage wasn't too severe.

Pointer: Only three months left, yet our latest "achievement" was a total catastrophe.

Pointer: I know what you're all thinking. That the odds are still good, and it's more or less safe to continue. But all that is a weighted gamble.

Pointer: Nothing matters more than your lives.

She knows this all too well. This is not her first time making bold gambles.

Researcher I: Pointer, what do you think the odds are really?

Pointer: Without diving into the calculations, it's around a 70% chance in theory. But my logic is screaming something else in my ear.

Researcher II: You ... you don't have to take that risk, Pointer.

Pointer: I know what I'm doing. Nothing's guaranteed in the world of science.

Pointer: I ...

She closes her eyes, interrupting the playthrough of her memories.

Pointer: The risk is too high. I can't allow it.

Hissabeth: But it's like we always say: there is nothing guaranteed in the world of science. You never know before you take that fateful step.

Such a firm, matter-of-fact statement. It sounds exactly like something the old Pointer might have said.

Pointer: My analysis points to a dangerous level of uncertainty in this project. The price of failure, even optimistically, could be much worse than a few days in recovery. There could be more permanent injuries. You could even ...

The "Storm."

Pointer scans the room. None of them have known failure—not yet—and they shouldn't have to.

Pointer: You've seen how things, places, people just disappear in the "Storm."

Pointer: You need to stop this insanity before that happens to us. Don't you understand?

Hissabeth: I really don't. Why should we stop?

She thinks for a moment, then a spark of inspiration flashes across her face.

Hissabeth: No, you're right. We shouldn't pretend as if it's normal to risk our lives for this. At the end of the day, if we die, our research dies with us.

Hissabeth: But if something were to happen to the team, you would be the one to survive. That's why I want you to keep our records, to take down everything in case the worst happens.

Hissabeth: Here.

Pointer looks down at the data card.

Machines are only capable of faithfully recording and replaying data. They can't interpret meaning. They certainly cannot understand the reckless choices of human beings.

Those who come after might skim through the logs and learn how the team met, chose, collaborated, and parted ways.

But what about everything outside the frame? The temperature of the lab, the taste of a restaurant's signature dish, the hesitation she feels right now. No device can preserve those details—only memory can.

Some need to move forward. Others need to stay behind.

She doesn't look up and never reaches for the disk. She's made up her mind.

Pointer: I won't take it, and I won't submit this petition for you. I can't stand by and let you kill yourselves.

Pointer: I'm done. I quit.

A Freezing Rain

CO-10

1987, Plesetsk
2 months before the "Storm"

The name is Pointer. Researcher in the LSCC Plesetsk Branch.

The reason I joined? The same reason I quit.

Nothing matters more than people's lives. All the research I've done has been for one purpose: to make people's lives better.

Hall, Laplace Branch

Windsong: Pointer, there you are! How's everything going?

Windsong doesn't mind her quitting. Whenever she runs into Pointer at the branch office, she always stops for a few words, often with updates on the aerospace team.

Windsong: I heard you're busy with the evacuation. Seems many stores in Mirny have already closed up.

Pointer: As soon as I finish the handover here, I'm heading back into town to help with packing, coordinating, and explaining the situation to the locals. Same old, same old.

Windsong: "Same old, same old." You know, Hissabeth said that exact thing when I asked about the team's progress yesterday. They seem to be doing alright.

Pointer: Good.

Windsong takes a small bag out from her coat, nudging the conversation in a lighter direction.

Windsong: Oh, by the way, I've got some seeds left. Do you wanna take them off my hands?

Pointer: Do I look like a gardener to you?

Windsong: Well, it's just that I heard from a few people here in Mirny that a Laplace researcher was giving out sunflower seeds.

Windsong: And it wasn't me, so I've been wondering just who it could have been.

Windsong: Don't you want some? Seriously, everyone loves them.

Pointer: ...

On the day Pointer left the Plesetsk Cosmodrome, she handed out these seeds to everyone she passed.

What was she thinking? Maybe she just wanted to break all ties, to stop herself from turning back.

She keeps this bag, saving it for the right moment.

Pointer: Thanks.

Pointer: So, who ended up signing the application?

Windsong: Hissabeth will, when she goes to collect the monitor and report our research to Ludwig. She says it's more likely to get approval that way.

Pointer: They don't know when to stop, do they?

Windsong: They don't know the meaning.

Hissabeth: Stop.

Hissabeth: If the fish get startled, then they won't eat anything.

Kiperina: I see, Ms. Hissabeth.

She sprinkles the fish food carefully over the water's surface, hoping these fragile little creatures might cling to some instinct to survive.

Name Day: I finished a full inventory check. There's more runium left than we thought. Now, where should I put these useless old files? I was thinking we could use them for draft paper.

Hissabeth: Maybe you can turn them into a knife or something.

Hissabeth: A knife would be more useful at this point. You know, to cut fruit or whatever.

Name Day: Actually, that card there on the table would work better for that.

Hissabeth: Why is that?

Name Day: It's all about the material. Metal makes a better edge than paper. Never quite understood why you made them like that.

Hissabeth: Oh. I was testing out the new alloy. I used it to make Windsong's and Pointer's cards. It gets harder and sharper when heated. Give it a rub with your hands, and you can use it as a letter opener.

Their words trail off. They've been trying not to bring up Pointer's departure, to pretend like everything is still just as it was.

Hissabeth: The ritual still isn't stable enough. We need a specific location or area to set as a destination in advance.

Hissabeth: But first, we need a way to pinpoint a recognizable area.

Hissabeth: The formula should be ...

Name Day: Ms. Windsong sent me a message. She said: "Don't forget to collect the monitor."

Hissabeth: Oh, she sent it to you too? Tell her I said thanks.

Hissabeth: No, that number doesn't look right.

Han Zhang: I tried my best, but those arcane minerals you were asking for are scarce as all hell! I haven't been able to find a single supplier.

Hissabeth: Then, we'll carry on without them.

Hissabeth: That's it.

Hissabeth: Nope. Wrong again.

Hissabeth: Pointer was the master of numbers. With that brain of her, she'd have had this over and done by now.

A sound from the corner of the room draws her attention. Voyager is stacking pieces of mineral shards into a wobbly tower.

In the lamplight, the peak sparkles, strangely mesmerizing.

Hissabeth: Careful, don't hurt yourself. They're more powerful than they seem.

Voyager nods with a vague but accepting gesture, and Hissabeth turns back, ready to refocus on the data.

But the fragile silence is broken, and other words spill out.

Kiperina: Ms. Hissabeth.

The little would-be astronaut walks over and stands beside Hissabeth. It's rare for her to approach so closely.

Kiperina: I have a question for you. Sorry if it's not a good time, but it's important to me.

Kiperina: And it's something I hope you'll answer honestly.

Startled by the coming topic, Name Day broke the fish tank accidentally. He scrambles to scoop up the spilling fish from the floor.

Name Day: Sorry, ladies. Please ignore me. I'm not here, and I didn't hear a thing.

Name Day: Ms. Kiperina is a smart young lady. It's hardly surprising that she'd be quick to figure things out, don't you agree?

Hissabeth: ...

Hissabeth looks down at her. The upturned face is young, but so very determined.

Hissabeth: So, what's your question?

Kiperina: Ms. Pointer said something before she left about places and people disappearing into the "Storm."

Kiperina: It's hard to believe that she would ever give up on our mission, unless she knew the price of failing was truly horrible.

Kiperina: Then the "Storm" can't just be some normal kind of natural disaster.

Kiperina: This "Storm" will destroy everything, won't it?

She doesn't even know how long that question has sat in the pit of her chest. In her glass-marble eyes, Hissabeth sees a brightness welling up.

She doesn't know how to respond. But silence can be an answer, too, and the girl understands.

Kiperina: All the people we know? All the bears, birds, these fish, everything?

Kiperina: The lost future that you talk about, was it the first to disappear? Or are there more that have been lost? Will the same thing happen to our time?

Kiperina: Things are much worse than you let on.

Kiperina: What else has changed in the future?

The light in her eyes never fades—not completely. Kiperina has long understood that tears won't change anything.

Hissabeth: Many, many things changed. Some things won't last nearly as long as people think they will.

Hissabeth: For you, the world might seem to have turned upside down, but life will go on.

Pointer is gone. Windsong has her own geological surveys. Now everyone that's left seems to be looking to Hissabeth for answers.

She tries to choose her words deliberately, but she has hardly ever been comforted, so she doesn't know how to comfort others.

Hissabeth: So, now that you know what's at stake, are you ready to officially join Laplace?

Hissabeth: I'm afraid there is still a great deal I cannot tell you until then. Many of the answers you're seeking are classified, for employees only.

Name Day: Pardon me, Ms. Hissabeth.

Name Day: But given the danger of the mission we are expecting Kiperina to perform, I think she has the right to know what the "Storm" really is.

Kiperina: I understand that you don't want to go against Laplace's rules.

Kiperina: But I'll bet there aren't any rules against me figuring it out and you simply nodding, am I right?

Hissabeth nods. So Kiperina goes on.

Kiperina: I won't get to see Mr. Kozlov or get that gift in the future.

Kiperina: So, if I join Laplace, I won't see anyone from Utrennyaya ever again.

Hissabeth: ...

She hesitates but at last nods again.

Hissabeth: The choice is yours. I won't force you to do anything.

Hissabeth: Remember the day we first met in the restaurant? I said I would write you a recommendation. I was serious. I still am.

Hissabeth: In fact, it's already done. Windsong has signed on to it too, and our Foundation friend behind you is prepared to offer another guarantee just in case.

Hissabeth: We will make a recommendation for your friend Voyager as well, but that's all we can do. I'm afraid we can't protect everyone, nor can we make this decision for you.

Kiperina: ...

Hissabeth: Do you want to keep going?

The question isn't just for Kiperina.

If they recover the data—if that data is any good—maybe someday no one will have to worry about the "Storm" ever again.

But what if they put their lives in jeopardy and gain nothing from it?

Hissabeth: If you don't, you'll be allowed to return and accept what's to come, but if you join us, there is a chance to change things.

That is her answer—the only answer she needs to keep going.

Kiperina: I ...

Poems Come By Chance

CO-11

Silence has weight. Like sand piling, layer on layer, on one's chest, eventually it can suffocate.

The sobs barely register—two or three, snuffed out before they can burst.

Kiperina: I will complete my mission.

She speaks with clarity, as if making a solemn vow.

Kiperina: And if I successfully come back with the data, I'll consider joining Laplace.

Kiperina: But I can't make a decision now. I need more time to think.

Kiperina: I will stay until my job is done. You don't have to worry about that.

Kiperina: That is what Mr. and Mrs. Koslov and my friends in the circus would all want. It is the right thing to do.

Kiperina: ...

Kiperina: If you'll excuse me, I should return to my training. I'll see you later.

She's already on the move before the last word is spoken, leaving behind another layer of suffocating silence.

It doesn't take long before someone else tries to wriggle out from it, too.

Name Day: Us too. Need to double-check the warehouse inventory. Might find something useful.

Han Zhang: Wait, haven't we done that already? Those—

Name Day: Alright! We'll let you know if we find anything.

They leave the room one after another. In the corner, Voyager seems entirely unsure of what to do.

Hissabeth: Join them if you want. I have some unfinished business.

Voyager: ...

Moments later, the last light-footed silhouette exits the room.

Voyager: ...

The familiar gold glint rests at the far end of the hallway, her head lowered against the wall.

Voyager tries to approach but hesitates, stopping mid-step.

She looks around to make sure the hallway is empty, then lifts her violin onto her shoulder.

Voyager: ...

Voyager: Alia!

The music strings and her voice twist together like a trembling thread, calling her friend to turn around.

Kiperina: Was that you? Did you just say my name?

Kiperina: You learned how to—

As she sees those flickering sparks, her voice falters.

Then, in a heartbeat, Voyager resumes her usual appearance.

Voyager: Stars ... good.

Voyager: Alia, happy.

Hissabeth has the office to herself for once, but the progress she had hoped would come to her is still elusive.

After yet another failed calculation, she sets her pen down and reconsiders her goals.

Hissabeth: These calculations need to be finished today.

Hissabeth: The "Teleport" ritual requires the caster to recite the location. It could be understood as calibrating in a way.

Hissabeth: Let's continue with that thought.

Hissabeth: The destination must be preset, and the ritual cast through incantation ... But the further the distance, the harder it is to stay on target.

Hissabeth: If only there were an arcane reaction strong enough and unique enough to calibrate to ...

It's only then that she notices the strangeness of the moment, which is abruptly broken by the arcane energy monitor as it lets out an ear-splitting alarm.

A blinding light flashes across the entire screen, then cuts out.

The instrument's detection radius is small, barely beyond the nearby hallway.

Hissabeth: !

She narrowly avoids a full-on collision in the doorway.

Luckily, she catches herself using the girl's shoulder.

Kiperina: What happened? Are you alright, Ms. Hissabeth?

Hissabeth: Was that you? Did you cast that arcane skill just now?

Hissabeth: No, those energy levels were too high for you—beyond most arcanists. Who was with you just now?

Kiperina: Voyager.

Kiperina: She was just trying to make me feel better. Did it interfere with your experiments? I apologize, Ms. Hissabeth. I promise it won't happen again.

Kiperina: She just left. If you want to find her, I'll go with you.

Hissabeth: Are you saying she was the one that cast that arcane skill?

Kiperina: Yes. It was so pretty. It was like ...

Hissabeth: A neutron star.

It's obvious that the concept is beyond Kiperina. She tilts her head expectantly.

Hissabeth: It's a type of highly magnetized star that emits powerful beams that can be traced to show us its precise location. We call them the beacons of space.

Hissabeth: Such a strong arcane reaction would be so bright that it'd be trivial to locate even from an extreme distance!

Kiperina: I don't know much about space, but it sounds like the difference between finding a star in the sky and looking for the sun.

Kiperina: But then the universe is also very big. I imagine if you were looking from far enough away, even the sun would seem small.

Hissabeth: Damn! I'm afraid you're right. When comparing all the stars in the observable universe, our sun is far from the largest or brightest. Only the closest. We can't assume proximity in our case.

Hissabeth: But then, there's still got to be a way, non?

Capturing the fleeting aura, she propels a new train of thought forward.

Hissabeth: Before the "Storm" arrives, the levels of arcane energy in all affected areas will be greatly amplified. But, what about places that won't be affected?

Hissabeth: Perhaps then, the trick will not be to look for the light in darkness, but for the darkness in the light, like finding a dim bulb in a string of Christmas lights.

Hissabeth places her hands on Kiperina's shoulders and makes a promise.

Hissabeth: If that's the case, I can adjust the portion of runium in order to focus the disk precisely on Plesetsk!

Hissabeth: If this works out—

Hissabeth: Then I guarantee you will arrive home safe and sound.

1987, Plesetsk
2 months before the "Storm"

Pointer: Understood. Take care.

She ends the call and waves at the silhouette walking her way.

Windsong: What are you up to?

Pointer: I've been communicating with the garrison in Mirny. They've picked up some abnormal critter activity during their patrols.

Pointer: Another batch of residents is set to evacuate too. I'll head over to help them shortly.

Pointer: What about you—your geological survey? Are you staying at the branch, or will you head back to HQ?

Windsong: Haven't found anything that's worth digging up yet, but I've decided to give it another try. Should be back here in time for the evacuation.

Windsong: Though I'm hoping to stick around for my little apprentice. She said she'll only give us her decision on joining Laplace once she's back from her mission. I can't wait to hear the good news.

Windsong: You still pretending not to care?

Pointer: My concern, whether it exists or not, will have no tangible effect on their results. I just hope they don't kill themselves for nothing.

Windsong: Hissabeth is planning a final teleportation test the day after tomorrow. I'll be observing from the meeting room.

Windsong: You know the one we always use upstairs? Early in the afternoon.

Pointer: I'll likely be in Mirny by then.

A brief silence follows. In the pause, Windsong deftly shifts the topic to the conspicuous glass tank in the crowd.

Windsong: Hey, Ulrich! We meet again.

Windsong: You look even worse than when we last met.

Ulrich: Ah, Ms. Windsong? And Pointer?

Ulrich: What have we here, two of our busiest bees working together in the Plesetsk Branch?

Pointer has no idea why Ulrich looks "even worse." His expression, as ever, is nigh unreadable, so she simply nods to him.

Windsong: So, when is this "humanitarian vacation" of yours over? Any interest in sparing a little time to watch something fun?

Ulrich: If by "something fun" you mean Dmitry's party, then thanks, but no, thanks.

Windsong: No, not that. I told you about it before—Hissabeth's teleport disk experiment.

Ulrich: Ah, yes, that one. You know word of it is already spreading through HQ and all the other branches?

Windsong: And? What's the impression?

Ulrich: I wouldn't categorize it as "good," but it has certainly become a contentious topic.

Windsong: At least one of the bigwigs is supportive—Madam Lucy. It seems she intends to keep our experiment going either way. She even invited a prominent String-Theory Researcher to HQ.

Windsong: As I said, even if we don't get the results we hoped for, the work itself can be illuminating.

The silent researcher at last offers a wave to attract the attention of the room.

Pointer: Excuse me. I have obligations to attend to.

Pointer: Let's talk again later.

She walks off, leaving Ulrich and Windsong to watch her as her figure passes into the hall and away.

Several minutes pass, then Windsong gasps.

Windsong: S**t! I forgot my badge, and Pointer's gone. How am I supposed to get back to the lab?

Windsong: Sorry, Ulrich, do you mind walking me back?

Windsong: By the way, you didn't answer whether you'll be at Hissabeth's experiment.

To Camille

小径

To Camille

Dear Camille,

How long has it been since we last spoke? The long tug-of-war with the cold drained all my energy. Only today did I manage to warm up enough to dip my tail in ink and write to you.

Sylvie is doing well. Maxime and Alexandre always help her think in parallel, and Monique, as usual, keeps things under control at critical moments. Serpentes has been showing more and more signs of thought lately. I think it's only a matter of time before he speaks. Hélène is sleepier than ever, staying in heated rooms around the clock.

As for Chantal and Pierre, they're the same as always.

And me? I didn't just hibernate. The local literature has filled the gaps in my collection that Sylvie once ruthlessly discarded.

The Melusines were deeply moved by these authors' vivid portrayals of suffering and death, yet even within the darkest themes, the authors' exploration of new paths brimmed with vitality, dreams, and a defiant sense of romanticism.

Whenever I read the literature to her, her memories become unusually vivid, and she recalls one line in particular with striking clarity from Pasternak's February: "The truest verses arise by chance, tempered in the fire of pain."

Of course, there's no way to verify this and Sylvie would never admit it, but I believe she's the most romantic in our family. Or maybe the second-most. After me. I wish you were part of the Dubois family too. That way, you'll truly understand what Sylvie's memories feel like when she sees a shooting star.

I truly hope we can talk about all of this someday. Maybe after Sylvie's little challenge is complete, you could visit Plesetsk. I promise Sylvie and I will both be warmly waiting to welcome you.

Your dear friend,

Estelle

Concerto

CO-12

1987, Plesetsk Cosmodrome
2 months before the "Storm"

There's not much difference in the lab today. Even though the others had tried to tidy up the clutter, any attempts at organization are doomed to fail here.

Hissabeth pushes the last stack of files to the corner of the table, then steps back to survey her work.

Hissabeth: I'm ready. Remember to stay within the safe zone.

Hissabeth: The medical team is helping with the evacuation, so we need to be extra careful this time.

Kiperina: Miss, are you sure I shouldn't be the one doing this? I've mastered my arcane skill. I'll be able to protect myself.

Hissabeth: No, no, no. Look at all the files here. They might give you a paper cut. It's an unacceptable risk for our astronaut. Even the slightest abrasion could explode under the pressure of lift-off.

Hissabeth: No need for concern. We've done the simulations and cross-checked the data thoroughly.

Hissabeth: To aid in the disk's mental preparation, I even read it Madam Lucy's speech and some Laplace essays on the scientification of arcane skills.

Kiperina: But—

Hissabeth: Kiperina.

Hissabeth's tone is formal, far more serious than she is known for in any other situation. Kiperina's back straightens.

Hissabeth: Take the others behind the blast door.

Hissabeth: I'll use my arcane skill to protect the field as much as I can.

Hissabeth: In order to maintain communication, you'll need to stay behind that door, or else the signal will be disrupted. But with my arcane skill, the risk should be minimal.

Kiperina: What if something goes wrong? What will you do?

Hissabeth: I will take care of myself. The only thing I ask is that you pay close attention to what I do.

Hissabeth: Because in the worst-case scenario, if you find yourself out there alone, you'll need to be able to perform this intuitively.

Kiperina: I don't know if I'm ready.

Hissabeth: Maybe, but it's still too early to give up, little astronaut.

She gives her a gentle push on the shoulder, nudging her back.

The automatic door begins to close.

Kiperina: But ...

She doesn't finish her sentence before the doors shut completely.

Hissabeth: Enough talking. We don't have time for any dramatic farewells.

Hissabeth: Wait, whose ID is this? Couldn't be Pointer's. She packs meticulously. Let me guess. Windsong?

She reads the words on the ID, smiling smugly at her confirmation.

Hissabeth: I knew it. How is she gonna get back into the lab?

Before activating the disk, she hangs the unexpected find around her neck.

Hissabeth: I'll just have to surprise her with it later.

Conference Room, Laplace Branch

In the empty meeting room, Ulrich and Windsong take up space on opposite sides of the door.

No one feels like sitting at the uncomfortable conference table without a good reason.

Ulrich: Where would you place their odds?

Ulrich: Perhaps more importantly, is there any guarantee the data they collect will elucidate meaningful truths behind the "Storm"?

Windsong: You know as well as I do. Laplace hasn't mastered the art of prediction. We don't offer guarantees.

Windsong: Besides, maybe our demon already knows how this all ends, but I'd rather not.

Windsong: Personally, I hate spoilers.

Ulrich: As do I.

Ulrich shrugs, about to continue the conversation by mentioning a neat bit of tech he's recently looked into, when a strange but familiar voice cuts in.

Monitor: Slackers? Slackers!

???: Yes, I've found the room. Thank you.

Ulrich's voice modulator stutters for a moment before finally spitting out the name.

Ulrich: Is that Adler?

Windsong: Mr. Ludwig?

Windsong looks stunned. Ulrich, clearly confused, flashes a giant "!" mark.

The raven perched on the monitor's head tilts its own in curiosity.

"Ludwig": I'm glad to see you're so devoted to our research, and I thank you for your hard work.

"Ludwig": I'm here to deliver the "Storm" Monitor on behalf of Madam Lucy.

"Ludwig": Given our lack of resources and time, we were forced to modify an existing device to perform as our monitor.

"Ludwig": It was originally a robotic assistant, something to set daily schedules and work reminders.

"Ludwig": You already noticed Adler's voice. It's synthetic, of course.

"Ludwig": His colleagues originally developed this machine for him as a "humanitarian gesture." It was trained to mimic his voice—an attempt to keep him social.

"Ludwig": It ultimately proved ineffective in that role, so now it will serve as our monitor.

Ulrich: I understand. Given the circumstances, recycling resources is wise. Though, I struggle to see how a robotic assistant could be a "humanitarian gesture."

"Ludwig": Your appreciation is noted. And I supposed you might. In fact, this vacation Madam Lucy sent you on to Plesetsk is a kind of "humanitarian gesture" on her part. Perhaps she hopes you'll gain a deeper understanding of the term.

Ulrich: ...

The raven, pleased with the silence, offers no further input.

Windsong taps a few times on the monitor and smiles at her new discovery.

Windsong: Mind if I take a closer look? Wow, there are a lot of voice packs programmed into this thing. "How to Temper Steel"—Madam Lucy's voice, I'd bet.

Windsong: And then, what else is here? Sweetheart, the superstar? Oh, and Sputnik-1 too.

Windsong: "Warm and Fluffy Company," who could that be?

Monitor: '%#@&*$#!

Ulrich: What a waste of time! Why would a monitor need a critter's voice in space?

Windsong: Maybe they just put it in for fun. It could be useful to relieve a little stress.

Windsong: Oh, perfect timing. Hissabeth has entered the testing grounds.

Hissabeth: Field report. I activated the disk, but it's not working. There must be an error in its incantation.

Hissabeth: Oh, the indicator is red, so then it must still be accumulating arcane energy. It may be calibrating its position within the range I set.

Hissabeth: But what about all this excess energy? I worry it might not just transport me but half the office.

Han Zhang: Any last words? If you explode, I call dibs on your fish.

Hissabeth: Have some patience. It's doing something.

She shakes the disk once or twice, but when she stops, it continues to tremble—

—violently.

The entire office begins to rattle along with it. The fish in the eco-tank dart anxiously.

Hissabeth: Bad news: I don't think any of those fish are gonna survive.

Hissabeth: Wish me a safe journey!

Before the floor starts to ripple, the monitor scoots itself out into the hallway for safety.

Windsong slams her back against the wall to steady herself. Looking up, she sees Ulrich's glass tank vibrating, its contents scattering into tiny particles.

Windsong: I can hear you brainstorming, Ulrich. It's oddly literal.

Ulrich: ...! ..., ...!

The sound of shattering glass immediately has Windsong turn to her colleague, confirming that Ulrich is still secure inside his case.

The noise appears to have come instead from a fish tank falling and—

Hissabeth: Hey, watch out!

Windsong: You know, Hissabeth, there's gentler ways to make an entrance.

Hissabeth: I—can't—hear—you!

The voices around her, whether in her headset or her ears, are garbled, twisted by the movement of space.

Midair, Hissabeth adjusts her posture and lands squarely on the meeting table.

Aside from the poor fish that were flung from their stone tank, it isn't the worst entrance.

The fish flopping on the floor begin to slow, except the one that has landed fortuitously in Ulrich's tank.

Hissabeth: Poor fish. I attempted to turn my aquarium into a fireproof ceramic to keep it safe, but it looks like it just made it easier to shatter.

Hissabeth: Wait ...

Mention of her arcane skill triggers a panic. She glances down at the object she'd been handing to Windsong.

It's heavier than it should be. This must be Laplace's first ID badge with a ceramic strap.

Hissabeth: Uh-oh, I forgot about this.

Hissabeth: Luckily, it didn't affect the card itself.

She blinks, letting the shimmer of her arcane skill fade.

Windsong: That's a unique design. Thanks. It might make for a nice conversation piece.

Ulrich is busy saving the poor fish swimming atop his head, dropping it back into the tank.

Ulrich: Congratulations, Ms. Hissabeth.

Ulrich: Your results appear more than adequate. Indeed, you have exceeded my expectations.

Hissabeth: Is that stuffy-office talk for a good job? Merci, all the same.

Windsong: Congrats! So, does your success here mean my lovely apprentice has a chance to land back on Mother Earth safely?

Hissabeth: More than a chance now. Though, I'm afraid the adjustments we've made to the process will be impossible to replicate at scale.

"Ludwig": Nonetheless, you've convinced me.

The raven rolls toward them on its mechanical perch.

"Ludwig": Your application for delayed evacuation is approved.

The cheers in Hissabeth's headset reach her before she's finished processing the words.

Hissabeth: But I haven't even submitted it yet?

"Ludwig": Well, you may submit it now.

Han Zhang: So, that's why you're back here with that torn-up application form?

Han Zhang: I gotta tell you, it's impressive you managed to piece it back together.

All eyes fall on the thin sheet of paper, held together with tape and barely legible.

Hissabeth: At least I learned something from it: Don't teleport paper products without a protective sheath.

Kiperina: We seem so close to success.

Kiperina: I will keep training. I need to stay at my best for our launch day.

Voyager taps Kiperina on the shoulder, doing her best to express her opinion.

Kiperina: I know. I won't push myself too hard. Thanks, Voyager.

Name Day: We don't have much time left. Remember to rest too, while you still can.

Name Day: You should take a day off. Consider it a celebration of our successful experiment.

Kiperina: Actually, I believe Ms. Hissabeth already has plans for me. We still have a lot of work to do.

Kiperina holds her stare on the pondering researcher, expectantly seeking her input.

Hissabeth: Plans? Yes, that we do.

Hissabeth: I need to train you to use the monitor. You will have to confirm the final coordinates on the disk and be able to perform the final safety checks before launching.

Hissabeth: Oh, I think it may be necessary to implement a particular procedure that Ludwig mentioned.

Hissabeth: A "humanitarian vacation."

Where Ever Spring Stays

CO-13

1987, Mirny
29 hours before the "Storm"

Plesetsk, Mirny—whatever the name, the towns surrounding the Cosmodrome look more or less the same.

Town Street

They were built to support the nearby research facilities and fall silent along with them. A single snowflake goes unnoticed in the vast white, melting into hot breath.

Pointer: Allow me. These should be the last boxes.

Soldier: Leave them, miss. Just tell us which ones should be moved, and we'll take care of them. We all got our own jobs to do.

The young soldier bends down ahead of Pointer, loading the boxes into the truck one by one with practiced speed.

Pointer checks the list in her hands and gives a nod—correct quantity. The second-to-last batch of supplies is now loaded.

Pointer: Will you leave with the others tomorrow, or are you staying on until the final evacuation?

Soldier: Our orders are to evacuate to Zeno's nearest base tomorrow.

Soldier: How about you? We were responsible for escorting the last staff members from the Plesetsk Cosmodrome. That place should be empty now, shouldn't it?

Soldier: An evacuation like this has to be for something big. I'm sure you know better than I do.

Soldier: If you can, miss, find somewhere safe, ASAP.

Pointer: I'm leaving Mirny tonight, just as soon as I help finish with the evacuation.

Pointer: There are fewer troops around now. Have there been any further orders?

Soldier: Some were sent to clear the roads. There's been more critters blocking the way lately.

Soldier: I guess the others were assigned to an urgent support mission. So it's just the rookies like me left.

Pointer: Evacuations can be dangerous. A job like this shouldn't be left to new recruits.

Soldier: You think so? Honestly, I was hoping for a little challenge. But we're soldiers, we follow orders.

The engine roars to life, sending up a small flurry of snow from its undercarriage.

Soldier: Do you need a lift?

Pointer: Thanks, but I'm going back to check on the evacuation. Be safe.

The truck disappears down the slush-covered road carved through the snow. Pointer heads in the opposite direction, further into the town.

Han Zhang: So, this is our "humanitarian vacation" here? An open mining pit?

Hissabeth: You've got it.

Mining Pit, Mirny

Hissabeth: It's nearby and easy to reach. I can't see a reason why we shouldn't come check it out. The only problem is I got the timing a little off.

Hissabeth: But just you wait, it won't be long now before the aurora shows up.

She tosses a pebble toward the pit. It vanishes into the dark.

Hissabeth: We've recruited a great team from Laplace and the Foundation and worked out the kinks of our teleport disk. If we can just manage to collect some useful data ...

Hissabeth: Our future could be brighter than any aurora.

Name Day: I hate to be negative at a time like this, but this is still a big gamble.

Hissabeth: But we won big today. Didn't you join us to bring about a better future? Just think, our achievements on this project could pave the way to a promotion or at least a transfer.

Name Day: Don't try to butter me up with promotion talk. Anyway, it's bad luck to talk like that right before a mission. Worse than bad luck—it's cliche.

Name Day: Strangers coming together to do great deeds, risking mortal peril for the good of humanity. Now, just before the climax, we'll start talking about our motivations and backstories.

Name Day: All to give the story a twist: when someone bites it in the last act, and then the whole gang is haunted by their last moments of peace together.

Han Zhang: Oh, there's a theory about that! What is it called again? Right, quantum entanglement.

Han Zhang: Where I'm from, there's a book called Yijing that has a similar idea, that the things we do are mirrored in faraway places.

After turning several near-identical corners, Pointer reaches her destination.

A small group of people has gathered by the roadside. The moment they spot her, their wind-chapped faces break into smiles.

Pointer: How are things proceeding? I'm here to perform a final check on the evacuation.

Resident: It's going well. We're all ready to leave.

Resident: It's just these flowers. We thought about planting them somewhere, just so we don't need to carry them, but with the soil frozen over ...

Pointer: Flowers?

Resident: Yes, you know, from the seeds you gave us. My daughter planted them just for fun, but they really thrived!

A little girl bundled in thick winter clothes hoists up her box of treasures to Pointer—several tall potted sunflowers.

Child: Mommy said it's really really difficult.

Child: It's a miracle! Miss, but you and I did it together!

Pointer: Yes, I suppose it indeed appears miraculous. But how are you going to take them with you? I think it will be a bit too heavy to carry on the road.

Resident: We've given away the rest to some of our neighbors. But these are the ones that bloomed the best. It hurts to think we'd just leave them here to die.

Resident: It's so cold now, and it's getting hard to find food. We know we have to evacuate soon, but no one has told us where we're going, or what's next.

Resident: Despite all the hardship, these seeds you gave us somehow managed to bloom under my daughter's care. Look, they're absolutely radiant!

Resident: If even these little flowers are ready to fight to survive, how can we give up?

The townspeople around her chime in, and the girl beams even brighter, holding the box tight in her arms.

Pointer: That's true.

She wants to tell them to save their space and energy for more important supplies.

The seeds were a gift from Windsong, likely altered through an arcane skill, perhaps already adapted to grow in permafrost.

But at this moment, it doesn't seem right to judge these flowers that hold meaning for others.

Pointer: Thank you. I'm not aware of the local species of flowers here, but I'm certain all the same that these are the most beautiful flowers in Mirny.

Pointer: I hope you can find a way to take them with you.

Watching the golden hue of the sunflowers fade into the distance, Pointer steps back onto the street.

She will check on the vehicle she parked earlier, take one final patrol, and then leave, without looking back.

Yet Mirny is, in fact, just large enough for chance encounters to still occur.

Laplace Staff Member I: Hey, am I seeing things? Pointer?

The glint of a Laplace uniform blends into the snow, and she squints until she recognizes the waving figure.

Pointer: Oh, hey! Weren't you on vacation? Why are you back here with the evacuation team?

Laplace Staff Member I: Well, I had nothing else to do anyway, and we need all the help we can get.

Laplace Staff Member I: Did you hear? There's still a team at Plesetsk. Ludwig even approved a delayed evacuation for them.

Laplace Staff Member I: I guess they're planning to stay to the very last moment. Can you believe that?

Pointer: Ludwig actually approved it? They are going to stay in the Cosmodrome?

The news is nothing like she expected. Her voice rises in shock.

Laplace Staff Member I: Unbelievable, right? That takes a lot of guts. Who would have guessed we had people like that here at Laplace?

Laplace Staff Member I: If you've got time, maybe you should go check on them, see if you can talk some sense into them.

He aims to pat her shoulder. But considering her mechanical components, he lowers his hand halfway.

Laplace Staff Member I: Anyway, I have a street of houses to check one by one for stragglers, so I've got to get back to it.

Laplace Staff Member I: Oh. It's freezing cold out there. Don't forget to check the components. I'll catch up with you when we get back to the branch.

Pointer: ...

She once hoped that Ludwig would shut down this absurd plan—a mission with far greater odds of failure than achieving any meaningful goal.

But she should've known better. Laplace is filled with the most stubborn people imaginable. They would never give up, no matter how many obstacles stand in their way.

The "Storm" is coming. What else is left for her to do?

Pointer looks in the direction of the Cosmodrome, the buildings obscured by a swirling sheet of white.

Han Zhang: Everything is made of atoms. From afar, Mount Taihang is like a grindstone, the Yellow River is like a belt, and all these things are but dust.

Han Zhang: In other words, maybe the reason why we're here is only a complete coincidence.

Hissabeth: Hold it, hold it, let's just get back to the topic at hand. I think I'm allergic to poetry.

Kiperina: Aww, I want to hear the rest. Would you please let him finish?

Hissabeth: No way. I think I'd rather take a chance on that lethal backstory cliche. How about you start us off?

The little snakes tilt their heads in unison. Every eye lands inquisitively on Name Day.

He almost wishes for a petrification spell to hit himself.

Name Day: Um, sure. What do you want to know?

Name Day: Are you curious about why I chose our loose yet ambitious team?

Hissabeth: "Loose yet ambitious," that's a good description.

Hissabeth: You brought it up. Now spit it out, and make it simple.

Name Day: Maybe I shouldn't have oversold it. I just think you have a good plan.

Name Day: What if this works? What if we do this and it changes the world? And I could be a part of that? It's a tempting thought. Don't you think?

Name Day: I just don't want to see another place I hold dear lost to the "Storm."

Hissabeth: So, you mean it was for your hometown?

Name Day: Yeah, I guess you could say that.

Kiperina: Isn't your homeland still here in this era?

More often than not, Kiperina chooses to listen and wait. She seldom inserts herself into conversations.

Kiperina: Have you just accepted the fact that it will disappear ... again?

He shakes his head.

Name Day: My home isn't in this era. Maybe the names are the same, same old familiar buildings, but nothing that matters to me. What's gone is gone.

Name Day: Don't feel bad for me though. Now, I have my own "portable hometown."

He raises a finger and taps the little ornament dangling on his ear.

Hissabeth: Hey, I always figured you kept that around in case you needed some quick cash, you know, like those pirates that had coin earrings.

Name Day: Oh, no. My brother said he would kill me if I gave this away.

Name Day: It's meant to be for "the last living child," a family heirloom of sorts. If I lost it, I think my family would crawl out of their graves and haunt me, if they had graves. Still, if I was in dire need ...

"Family." The word stirs emotions in all those listening.

Kiperina lowers her head, trying to hide her expression.

Voyager: A-Alia, family?

She points to the ground, doing her best to respond with the words she's learned, even if the meaning is slightly off.

Kiperina: No, Voyager, this is not my family. They're in Utrennyaya.

Kiperina: These are my friends.

Voyager: Friends.

She knows this word, but until now she only used it to describe Kiperina.

For Kiperina, it's a word that breaks down barriers and opens doors.

Kiperina: You told me that as long as there are living people to remember what has been, that what we're doing will be worthwhile. I've tried to accept that, but I still can't.

Kiperina: What has been ... It's not just an old building or some candy in a store. It's the place I grew up and the people I love that will be taken away.

Kiperina: It's everything in my life. It is my life.

Kiperina: I know I must accept it, that I can do nothing but accept it, but how can I ever accept it?

Another long silence.

Everyone standing here has a reason to keep going—reasons strong enough to chase the absurd.

In other words, no one here knows the real answer.

We Who Chase the Stars

CO-14

The hardest person to convince is often yourself.

Sensing Kiperina's disappointment, Name Day finally speaks up.

Name Day: About that ...

Hissabeth: I don't know.

The blunt reply causes him to bite his tongue and listen.

Hissabeth: When I heard about my parents' deaths, I was just stepping onto the bus to Laplace. I felt like I had no time to even think about it.

Hissabeth: I guess I mistook that for acceptance. After all, there's nothing I could do to change it.

Hissabeth: Then about three months later, I broke my pen while writing a research log.

Hissabeth: I cried for 40 hours. FORTY HOURS. And I'm not exaggerating. I'm grateful my roommate didn't have me committed.

Kiperina: Was it your parents' pen?

The very idea of Hissabeth crying seems almost impossible to imagine. She cuts off the thought before it turns impolite.

Hissabeth: Nah. Just an ordinary Laplace office pen. They give them out by the box load.

Hissabeth: But back home when I broke something, my parents would tease me for being careless, and then we would find a new one together.

Hissabeth: You can't really accept a thing like this. The only thing you can do is put your pain aside and find something to do with yourself.

Hissabeth: Even if it's just making a ball of tape. Just wrap a ball, round and round, over and over, until you've forgotten what it even looked like inside.

Kiperina: Maybe that is something I can try.

The little astronaut nods solemnly.

Hissabeth: Cool, you should. I'm speaking from my experience. You know, when you're young, everything bad seems like the end of the world. Forgetting your homework might as well be the apocalypse.

She's right. Name Day swallows the words he had meant to use to lighten the mood.

He's heard enough of them before. He's even asked himself the same.

Avgust: Are you going home, Mr. Raccoon?

Name Day: No, I'm heading out for a mission.

Avgust: Vila said it's a time that you're familiar with, but that you didn't ever plan on going back.

Avgust: I know Vila had another home before she moved to Rayashki. You must have one too!

Avgust: What was it like? Does it snow there?

Name Day: Yes. It snowed there, so much that it made the trees sag and covered up your footprints as soon as you walked past.

Name Day: When the Volkhov froze over, my sister and I would go and fish from holes we cut in the ice.

Avgust: Comrade Pasono once fell in the ice doing that. We didn't see him at school for weeks.

Name Day: Playing on the ice can be dangerous, little Avgust.

Legend has it that girls who drown become Rusalki. He asked Vila once, and she confirmed it was only a myth.

Most stories are like that, heavily embellished in the retelling.

To hold the boy's drifting thoughts or rein in his own memories, he squats down until his head is level with the sunflower.

Name Day: But it's all gone now. No matter the era, even if I went back to that little dot on the map, it would never be the same.

Avgust: Like Rayashki.

Name Day: Just like Rayashki.

Another patch of land whose story was lost to the "Storm." Remembered only by the few lucky enough to have lived there.

He tries to pull the topic back before it veers somewhere neither of them can handle.

Name Day: That is why we must stay alive, then things will work out some day.

???: Lyonya, stay alive. That's the most important thing.

???: Keep going. Follow the route I told you. Never look back.

Foundation Registrar: Being certified as capable for an independent field mission means you're an official Foundation member. Congrats in advance.

Foundation Registrar: Most people here use an alias, though it's all up to you. Just make sure you pick a good one. It's not easy to change once it's confirmed.

Leonid: I see. Thank you for telling me.

The day he left home came close to another date soon to be celebrated.

That's it.

He hands over his application form.

Foundation Registrar: Let me check. Alright, no problem.

Foundation Registrar: The "Storm" has made everyone's life harder here. The Foundation is always in need of more manpower, and in need of honest men like you even more so.

Foundation Registrar: Welcome to the St. Pavlov Foundation Far East Branch, Mr. Name Day.

A name means existence.

What is hard to accept? Knowing that your city can't be found on any map, or that city still shares its name but has changed entirely.

He's tried before, but his arcane skill doesn't work on living beings. That fleeting glow he remembers is probably just an illusion.

Avgust: You're thinking about something. Missing your home again, yes?

Avgust: It's okay. Vila said as long as we pay attention in class and keep learning, we will be able to rebuild Rayashki in the future.

Avgust: We will rebuild it as long as each and every comrade keeps that goal in their mind, and I will never forget.

The sunflower tilts its head. The boy mimics it, then he pats his friend's shoulder, offering a little encouragement.

Avgust: You can do it, Comrade Raccoon.

Name Day: Thank you very, very much, Comrade Avgust.

Name Day is still lost in thought as the aurora begins to spill across the sky.

It follows its own patterns, constant and resplendent, existing without the need for names.

Nothing in nature is made for humanity.

Hissabeth: Come here, Alia. You can have the best seat.

Kiperina: Oh, I think for now, I'd prefer to be called Kiperina.

She mutters something more under her breath but still finds herself sitting in the offered spot.

Hissabeth: Hurry up. You don't get an aurora like this every night.

Hissabeth: You need those charged particles up there for your arcane skill.

Kiperina: I thought we were here for a vacation.

Hissabeth: It can be more than one thing. You do need this though.

She finds a suitable rock to sit on and brushes the dust off the stones beside her for Kiperina and Voyager.

Hissabeth: Stay calm. Walking in space is definitely going to be easier than walking a tightrope.

Hissabeth: There's no absolute direction up there. Up or down depends on the reference you choose.

Hissabeth: In short, there's no "falling down."

Kiperina nods seriously.

Kiperina: Tomorrow, no, the day after tomorrow, I'll be up there drifting above the Earth with the stars.

Kiperina: I wonder if they'll feel warm to the touch.

Whether from nerves or the night wind, she shivers.

Hissabeth opens her arms wide to pull both girls into a huddle.

Kiperina: The night is so cold. Back with the Utrennyaya, on nights like this, I would sneak into the pens and sleep beside Masha—the bear cub I took care of. She was so warm to cuddle.

Kiperina: And now I'm here, huddled with all of you. Oh, sorry, I'm not suggesting you remind me of bears.

Kiperina: It just feels safe.

Name Day: There were times, during the coldest winter nights, that my siblings and I would cuddle up with the stray dogs to keep ourselves warm.

Han Zhang: Hold on. You people don't just hibernate through the winter? You're missing out.

This is the first time their little team has sat together without the mission on their minds, chatting instead about past lives and faraway memories.

Before she realizes it, sleepiness sneaks up on Kiperina.

She stands to shake off her sudden drowsiness, and Hissabeth rises with her.

Hissabeth: Alright, we should head back. We don't want our little astronaut to be too tired.

Han Zhang: Hey, you think I don't see what you're doing? You haven't told us your story yet.

Han Zhang: It's been on my mind since I first got here: why would you do all this? You don't strike me as the hopeless dreamer type.

Hissabeth: I don't? Well, I should make more of an effort to match the stereotype.

She tilts her head just enough to catch the dozing little snake and nudge it back onto her shoulder.

Hissabeth: It's not so dreamy though. I just wanna know the answers. Where do we come from and how things will end?

Hissabeth: What? Not convincing enough?

Hissabeth: Perhaps you want something more in-depth?

Hissabeth: Way back when, before all this, Pointer and I were being driven mad by work, we would walk out here and there was something she would say to me.

She narrows her eyes, watching the shifting curtains of light with interest.

High-energy solar particles, shaped by Earth's magnetic field, dance across the sky in colors visible to the naked eye.

If you listen closely, you might even hear their faint crackling.

Hissabeth: Language is a tool that permits us to describe how the universe was created and how it will end.

Hissabeth: Through it, we reflect on our existence. In order to understand eternity, we must first understand death and impermanence.

After a small shake of her head, she regains her usual casual tone.

Hissabeth: What do you think? Good impression of her, non? Everyone says it's my best.

The aurora hanging high above the sky shines down at the people below. Brilliant beams fall, blurring the edge between snow and sky and softening every expression into something unreadable.

Hissabeth's voice feels like it's coming from far away.

Hissabeth: Tomorrow might be our last free day before the "Storm." I guess it's fitting then to ask the age-old question:

Hissabeth: If tomorrow was the last day of your life, what would you do?

Cabinet of Wishes

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Cabinet of Wishes

Become Director. Drink endless wine. Succeed in projects.

World peace. Conquer the galaxy. Go home for a visit.

Live to see next year. Touch Mars with your own hands. Establish relations with alien life.

Grow flowers in Siberia. Free yourself from material needs. Become a true engineer.

Defeat death. Marry Anastasia. Witness history.

Time to Say Goodbye

CO-15

1987, Plesetsk Cosmodrome
17 hours before the "Storm"

The little soon-to-be astronaut stands before the heavy blast door and presses her finger against the scanner.

Just like several months before, she walks the quiet corridor on the way to her training.

Kiperina: Do everything we can, and do my best.

Kiperina: Leave no regrets.

Kiperina: That's why I have to finish my training.

The closer she gets to the end, the more the nerves take hold.

So, she looks for comfort in steady, familiar routines.

One, two, three.

She finishes her count silently. Right on cue, the blast doors slide open.

The weightlessness calms her. Compared to the other simulated operations, arcane skill practice, and centrifuge spins, this is her favorite routine.

It's like walking a tightrope, but without the fear of falling.

With gravity out of the picture, the sky itself feels reachable, the world stretching out like a velvet blanket around her.

If this is the last day of my life,

how can I prove that I was here in this world? With my name, my memories?

I remember what they called me:

Alina Medvedeva. The girl like a bear.

You must have a proper stage name for your performance.

Mr. Kozlov: "Kiperina."

Mr. Kozlov: What do you think? Natalya and I decided on it together. She's a clever one, always reading the latest astrological lectures.

Mr. Kozlov: It's from a place in the stars. Kuiper, she calls it, some asteroid belt made of ice.

Mr. Kozlov: This is because, to us, you are a gift from the stars!

He lifts her high, steady and secure. To a child, it feels like flying.

So close to a starry sky built from light bulbs and canvas.

Mr. Kozlov ... Mrs. Kozlov ...

Natalya Kozlov: We're leaving tonight? Why all the rush? Let's wait one day later, or maybe two. Why don't we ask that Laplace lady to see Alia again?

Mr. Kozlov: I am sure she is too busy. But look, everyone's leaving town! Something must be happening.

He gestures to a place out in the distance, the dimly lit Cosmodrome barely visible against the night sky.

Mr. Kozlov: She'll be safe there. Didn't you hear them say that? Laplace's building will be the last to fall, even if the whole world comes to an end.

Mr. Kozlov: What we must do then is keep ourselves safe. That way, some day in the future, we will have the chance to see her again, sitting in the audience, clapping for us, until her hands are red.

Natalya Kozlov: My big bear wants to pretend he doesn't have a heart. I know you miss her as much as I do.

Mr. Kozlov: Of course, but I must stay in control of myself. Maybe we can put something on the signboard—a circle, like her space helmet.

Mr. Kozlov: You know that signboard hasn't been changed since my grandfather was the ringmaster. What a change it will be!

Natalya frowns as she struggles with the knots on their luggage, but straightens up when she hears the comment.

Natalya Kozlov: Yes, yes, and we will add some stars and spaceships. I'll paint them on once we're set up in Moscow. Oh, and don't forget to take down their address so we can send things to her.

Mr. Kozlov: You think I didn't do that the minute we came here? Natalya, you're showing so much concern. What happened to my carefree circus wife?

Natalya Kozlov: It's just that there is nothing else I can do.

She pats the package beside her—a few neatly wrapped dolls and a set of freshly cleaned costumes.

Natalya Kozlov: We've always been there for her. Now she's alone and far from us, who will care for her now?

Mr. Kozlov: *sigh* It is how it must be. We cannot be there for her forever.

Mr. Kozlov: You can't do this your whole life.

Mr. Kozlov: Audiences come to watch an acrobat fly, but they also come to see if they will fall.

Mr. Kozlov: Most people would never dare to walk on a tightrope.

Mr. Kozlov: They pay to see people do the thrilling things that they would never do themselves.

Mr. Kozlov: But it is a dangerous business. I often wish that you will one day find a safer way to live than this.

Is walking on the ground really any safer?

How long will my life be?

Eight years, ten years, 15 years? What's next? When will it end?

Hissabeth: Time never ends. It's a concept, and there are many explanations for it.

Hissabeth: One suggests that since the whole world is made of particles, including our brains, then our minds too can be calculated, so that everything that's happening or about to happen can be predicted.

Hissabeth: Past, present, future. All that ever was, and is, and ever will be, was destined from the moment the universe began. Each moment like a knot on a string that's already been tied.

Hissabeth: Our lives just moving along a fixed track from birth to death.

Hissabeth: Then there is another, the theory that none of this is really happening at all, that all perception is illusion. Only the present exists, and only for as long as we're experiencing it.

Hissabeth: If you asked me to choose, I prefer the first one.

Kiperina: It's not like a tightrope then. When I walk on the rope, I don't see past and future. I only feel what is happening right now.

Kiperina: For example, these lights make my palms feel hot and warm. But the stones beneath me are cold.

Hissabeth: Cool, sounds like you favor the second theory.

Hissabeth: But it doesn't matter which side you're on. There's one thing both have in common.

Hissabeth: Our existence—whatever you make of it—is just a fleeting moment in time.

Kiperina: But those countless moments string together into eternity.

Kiperina: I'm small to the universe, just a person, but I'm a part of Utrennyaya, which is bigger than myself. We belong to a people, a country, a planet, and a galaxy.

Kiperina: Maybe that's how we share in eternity, by existing as part of it. Each one of us, no matter how small, takes part in creating the universe.

The researcher widens her eyes in brief surprise but just as soon returns to her usual confident and breezy smile.

Hissabeth: You got it.

Hissabeth: When we learn all the rules that govern our universe, we'll be able to predict all that is to come. We'll be able to survive without superstition and fear of the unknown.

Survive. That's easier said than done.

If we fail tomorrow ...

The "Storm" will wash away all that we've done here, everything I've ever known.

The only trace of it will be that recording, stuffed away in some dusty cabinet in the Foundation.

Even so, I hope one day, when they mention me, they will look up at the sky and say:

"A brave young astronaut walked among the stars."

It's not about Mr. Kozlov's wishes for Alia, nor about her friends' expectations for Kiperina.

And she, Alina Medvedeva, made the choice to go herself.

Natalya returns to the tent to retrieve the last few boxes of clothes, while Mr. Kozlov is busy tightening the ropes on the luggage.

There's a lot to pack. He tugs hard at the rope, tying the dolls Kiperina left behind safely onto a bundle, muttering the rest of what he didn't get to say earlier.

Mr. Kozlov: Children grow up, adults grow old, and then we die, so what's the use in worrying? All that matters is our Alia will be safe.

Pointer: Mr. Kozlov? You should have already left. The longer you wait to leave, the more dangerous it will be.

The man is startled. He's not good at dealing with researchers, and he never expected to run into one on the empty streets so late at night.

Mr. Kozlov: Is-Is there something wrong then? We are ready to go, as-as you can see. We're all packed up.

He motions to the stacked boxes behind him, his tone on the brink of pleading.

Pointer: No. Nothing to be concerned with for now. But we need you to follow the evacuation notice for your safety. Keep your passes with you. You may need to show the soldiers on the road ahead. And please take care. The snowfall is getting heavier.

Mr. Kozlov: Sure, sure. But if you don't mind my asking ...

Mr. Kozlov: Is Alia alright? How is she? How's her training? Sorry, it's just ... I know that she's a good girl, but I'm afraid she'll push herself too much. She's always been so diligent.

Pointer: You have nothing to worry about. Kiperina is a very disciplined and intelligent young woman. We've been most impressed with her work.

Pointer: I believe that she could have a very promising future with Laplace.

The fatigue on his face eases a bit, and some pride returns to him—the pride of a ringmaster.

Mr. Kozlov: Promising! I knew it. My Alia is a promising candidate for Laplace!

Mr. Kozlov: *sigh* When we first found her in Murmansk, she was just an orphaned babe. And now, see how wonderful she has become.

Pointer: I believe I understand. Time really does fly, doesn't it?

Mr. Kozlov: Thank you for telling me about her. I've wanted to pay her a visit, but I don't want to bother her, and I also don't think she wants to see an old man cry.

Mr. Kozlov: But if you say she is doing well, this is enough for me. But I must ask, miss. Why are you still in town? Aren't you going to be busy with the launch soon?

Pointer follows his eyes as he casts a look down the street. Bright fluorescent lights illuminate snow that swirls as it falls.

The snow falls on both of their shoulders. It melts on Mr. Kozlov, but it settles in layers on Pointer's metallic frame.

Pointer: I'm here to see if we missed anything.

What's About Time

CO-16

1987, Mirny
14 hours before the "Storm"

The lighting softens some of the chill, adding a touch of life to the empty tables and chairs.

The owner reaches out from behind the counter, pushing over a steaming cup and a small porcelain plate packed to the brim with gingerbread.

Restaurant Owner: Sorry, miss, but we've already packed everything away. I'm leaving on the last truck tomorrow morning.

Restaurant Owner: There was still some fresh food around yesterday, but today I've got nothing.

Restaurant Owner: All I can offer you is a mug of boiled water and some gingerbread.

Pointer: That will be enough. Thanks.

She got here a little late. This is the last place in town with a light on.

The owner rummages around for a while and manages to find a bucket of instant noodles and some other homemade treats.

She bites into a gingerbread cookie, the soothing spice and sweetness lingering on her sensors.

Pointer: Wow. This gingerbread tastes amazing.

Restaurant Owner: You bet. I'm originally from Novomoskovsk. We're famous for it. I think I told your friend the story last time she was here.

Restaurant Owner: I'm no good with hammers or rocks, but I know food, and the miners always work up a healthy appetite.

Restaurant Owner: My friend, Raisa, makes much better gingerbread than I do. Sometimes I think the only reason people eat here is for the conversation, heh heh ...

Restaurant Owner: The winter chill keeps everyone huddled inside. So, what else can you do but talk the long nights away?

Pointer: It is good to have someone to talk to. Still, I'm curious why you decided to stick around until the last minute.

Restaurant Owner: I'm in no rush. No one's bothered to explain why it is we have to evacuate, so I'll let all the young folks with something to live for get out first.

Restaurant Owner: Could I ask you a question as well?

Pointer: Sure, but I can't guarantee I'll have an answer.

Restaurant Owner: It's only that my friend lived in a town a lot like this, a mining town. They had their own big shots running things there too.

Restaurant Owner: In her last letter, she told me that those big shots were talking about evacuating them. Then, nothing. It's been years, and I haven't heard from her since.

The description seems eerily familiar.

Before she can say the name of the town, the owner shakes his head.

Restaurant Owner: Forget it, miss. It's a small town. I doubt you or anyone knows what really happened there.

Restaurant Owner: *sigh* I often wonder where she is now, or if she's even alive, but I hope that I will see her again some day.

Pointer: ...

It's the kind of question that can't be answered. The town she's thinking of no longer exists.

But she believes people need something to believe in.

Pointer: Sorry, I really don't know.

Pointer: Perhaps they did evacuate, but relocation can be complicated. It can take years. Maybe you'll hear from her again when she settles down.

Restaurant Owner: Yes, that's true. These things take time. Well, at least I can sleep at night.

The owner turns back to his packing, leaving her alone.

She takes a moment to examine the restaurant. In the vase atop the cabinet, a flower droops slightly, its color a bright golden yellow.

Pointer: Sunflowers.

The seeds given away so casually, like they meant nothing, are now blooming in corners everywhere.

There are still some ingredients on the shelves that haven't been packed, sealed bags and cans each occupying a small space.

Pointer: Freeze-dried apples, and ...

She attempts to scan their descriptions, but in the poor lighting, it's a lost cause.

Restaurant Owner: Oh, I forgot to pack those. It's amazing, isn't it, when you think about it? Even here in the far north, we can get fresh fruit and vegetables.

Restaurant Owner: I guess this technology was invented to make food for cosmonauts, but now people in Mirny get to enjoy it too! The benefits of science, heh heh.

Restaurant Owner: You can take some if you'd like. I have no room for them.

Pointer stares at the freeze-dried food on the shelf, momentarily dazed.

The research she once worked hard on, once thought meaningless, had found its way into daily life.

Pointer: Thank you. I'll be fine with just this. You've actually already helped me out a lot.

She tears open the instant noodle packet.

Pointer: No veggie packets, hah.

Pointer: Can my day get any worse?

Hissabeth: They act as if all of their essential and valuable consumer technology just popped up out of nowhere!

Hissabeth: To think that aerospace engineering has less to contribute than their other projects?! S**t! They wouldn't even have vegetable packets in their instant noodles without us!

Things close by, solid and clear in texture. Undeniable proof of existence.

She has always valued what can be felt and touched.

Pointer: Come on, pull yourself together, Pointer. We don't buy into karma.

Pointer: This is only another damn coincidence.

What price are you willing to pay for that answer?

Pointer: ...

This might be the most irrational decision she's ever made.

Having made up her mind, she begins her battle with the bucket of noodles in front of her.

Pointer: Tastes awful, hmph.

1987, Plesetsk Cosmodrome
13 hours before the "Storm"

Hissabeth: Final check.

Hissabeth: Spaceship?

Han Zhang: We've run a full diagnostic check. All components are operational. We're fully fueled, and we even installed that new insulation you invented.

Hissabeth: Data monitoring and communication systems?

Name Day: Check. All systems are functional, including the backups.

Hissabeth: Astronaut status?

Kiperina: I'm all checked out too. My arcane skill energy level, physical and mental status, and the integrity of my spacesuit are all within your parameters.

Hissabeth: Is there anything else we've missed? Anything at all?

She scans each person one by one until settling on the girl with curiosity burning in her eyes.

Hissabeth: Ah, what about our special humanitarian support staff? Maybe we should give her a check too.

Voyager: *a cheerful tune*

Hissabeth: Alright, dismissed. I'll see you at the launch bay doors in three hours.

Hissabeth: Now everyone, cool off a bit. We need to decompress before the action starts. Stay in touch via your communicators. I need everyone frosty. We're in the last mile now.

Hissabeth: There are still some things left to be checked through. If only we had more help.

As the others trickle out, Hissabeth's final inspection comes to an end.

She opens the drawer of her desk, stuffs the card lying in the corner into her pocket, and locks the door behind her.

The snow is trampled into muddy slush again and again, then flattened back into white. Pointer steps carefully, trying to follow footprints and tire tracks that haven't yet been covered.

There are no more voices in the town. Stripped of its adornments, Mirny is now cold bricks, scarred wood, and stained signs.

Boots and wheels once ground its days and nights into something solid.

The circus lights, the scent of food from the restaurant, the silver of the researchers' uniforms, and the occasional flash of gray plaid—all once decorated it and made it worth remembering.

Now it is a nameless ghost town, one of countless others.

Pointer: Mirny is so cold even in the daylight.

Pointer: At least the evacuation has gone smoothly.

No sooner has she said this than she notices a figure near the entrance of a shop.

Some flustered critter had wandered into the town and met its end. The soldiers likely didn't have time to deal with it properly and left its body in the snow.

The wild dogs, drawn by the faint scent of blood, arrive to enjoy a feast.

Pointer: Well, that's a security risk.

She calculates the best angle for a clean attack and starts to move.

Pointer: Scamper off and don't come back. I don't have time for another round.

The blood on her soles has been mixed with the snow, forming into icy red shards. Behind her, a trail of murky prints leads off across the snow.

Like red ribbons tied to trees marking a trail, this crimson path winds toward where the vehicle had been parked last night.

Pointer: I don't really know how much time I have left at all.

Pointer: These "Storm" predictions are based on fluctuations in arcane energy levels. There's even a chance that this won't be the "Storm" at all, just some kind of arcane phenomenon.

Pointer: No matter what the case may be, I can't afford an odyssey at a time like this.

Pointer: I have to get to the Cosmodrome, ASAP.

Launch Room, Cosmodrome

Hissabeth runs through delicate calibrations of all the equipment in the room. The snakes tilt their heads, thoroughly distracted by the many blinking prompts on the screen.

To focus, she tries turning the noise in her head into spoken words.

Hissabeth: Arcane energy fluctuations aren't a perfect method of predicting the "Storm."

Hissabeth: What if all these fluctuations are something else, something like that girl?

Hissabeth: Voyager, a mysterious girl with unbelievable power. I should let the Foundation handle this. I can't force her to join in an experiment against her will.

Hissabeth: There are too many redundant steps in the launching system. We need to streamline them if we're going to make our deadline.

She presses down firmly on the fingerprint scanner, keeping her tone civil through gritted teeth.

Snake V: **Aren't those steps important for safety?**

Hissabeth: Yeah, yeah, probably, but the process is too complicated. I think Pointer was the only one that ever managed to remember each step in order.

Snake V: **Oh, so now you're thinking of her again?**

Hissabeth: Yeah, whatever. I could use another hand, is all. She's probably still in the branch building, busy with her own stuff.

Hissabeth: Besides—

Snake V: **Hey, you hear that?**

Hurried footsteps approach the launch bay.

Snake V: **It's an intruder! Hurry, we've got to stop them!**

The little snake's mouth is pinched shut, and the room falls silent. She listens closely to the increasingly urgent steps.

Hissabeth: Effortless steps from a tall figure, with a tendency to lean forward.

Hissabeth: Sounds familiar. Could it be Windsong? Did she leave something behind again?

The figure that bursts into the room is unmistakably familiar. Unexpected, yet somehow inevitable.

Hissabeth: ...?

The Measure of a Melusine

CO-17

Pointer is visibly winded. Her vehicle couldn't drive into the inner perimeter of the launch bay, so she had to run the last stretch.

But she has to make the most of her time. She came back to say what needed to be said.

Hissabeth speaks first.

Hissabeth: Are you alright? You look like you haven't slept in days.

Hissabeth: How many times have I told you that research requires a healthy body and mind? You need sleep.

Pointer: I'm ... here for ...

Hissabeth: Just so you know, I've got no time to help with whatever you're working on, and we're finishing this project, no matter what you say.

Hissabeth: Oh, let me guess. You're here for the car? Yes, I've used it a few times, took the team out to the mine, didn't break anything or get any tickets, but the tank's dry.

Her every theory misses the mark.

Pointer: It's not about any of that!

Hissabeth: Then you should have come earlier—days earlier, not today.

Hissabeth: The "Storm" is due to come in a couple hours. You won't make it to the Northern Branch.

Pointer falls silent for a moment instead, adjusting her breath.

Pointer: I'm here to settle your affairs. We need to secure your records in case you don't make it, and to see if the work you've done is actually worth your lives.

Pointer: Just so you know, if you don't survive, I'm going to finish our teleport disk and claim all the credit. Maybe I'll write a dissertation on it. I'll call it "Pointer's Teleport Disk," and you'll all just be a footnote, an "et al." in the citations.

Pointer: You know I'm not bluffing.

Hissabeth: Cool, whatever, Pointer. Just don't forget to tell me the results. Maybe send them to me via Ouija board.

Pointer: Are you being serious?

Hissabeth: Aren't you? Or are you trying to be funny now? I really can't tell.

The casual air she fought to maintain finally breaks.

Pointer: I'm just sick of eating instant noodles without the veggie packets!

Pointer: But more than that, I'm sick of you and your attitude!

Pointer: All you do is joke around!

Pointer: If veggies matter that much to a stupid bowl of noodles, how could you think your lives matter any less to me?!

Pointer: You want to treat your lives like a cosmic joke? Like your deaths won't matter. Well, they will to the ones you leave behind.

After giving up on controlling her volume and her thoughts, she catches a different expression on Hissabeth's face.

Guilt, sadness, shock? None of the above.

She has simply put away her smile.

Hissabeth: I see your point.

Hissabeth: Luckily, I've already made a copy of everything on this data card.

A brighter, more genuine smile appears.

Hissabeth: I've been wondering who I should trust with it. It's not 100% safe to send back through the teleportation ritual.

Hissabeth: It's good to have you back.

The thin card is handed to her again.

Hissabeth: The editing isn't done. Han Zhang—yeah, I can remember his name now—I didn't have time to finish his part.

Hissabeth: But who has time to edit a suicide note?

Hissabeth: The only thing that matters is that it's in the hands of someone who will take it seriously.

Hissabeth: Take it and go. You can still make it back.

The data card feels faintly warm. It must have been in her pocket the entire time.

Pointer: *sigh* Forget it. You already told me the car's out of gas.

Pointer: So, I'll be your witness.

Hissabeth: You sure you wanna die with us, after all?

Pointer doesn't respond. She just takes a step forward.

Pointer: Call it a fool's wish, but I'm hoping no one is ever going to need to see this.

Pointer: Catch me up to speed, what's the status of the project?

Hissabeth: We've managed to refine the teleportation to pinpoint a fixed position, but there are still some serious side effects: dizziness, nausea, like the world's worst case of carsickness.

Pointer: It'll have to suffice for now. I think I can work that out after I finish reading your progress.

Hissabeth: Cool, I'll look forward to that.

She points to the door.

Hissabeth: Your office should be the same as you left it, besides a layer of dust. Be grateful though. You should see the state of mine.

Hissabeth: Oh, and don't activate the teleportation anywhere around here. If it takes out the single critical component, we'll be screwed completely.

Pointer: Like I don't know.

Pointer: You need a hand here? I can help.

Hissabeth: I thought we already figured out our roles? You need to stay at a safe distance to protect the data.

She can't quite tell if there's mockery in her words.

But she doesn't need to get to the bottom of it. Language is vague and fleeting. Words lose meaning the moment they're spoken.

Pointer: That's it.

Before turning around, she pauses and tucks her hair behind her ear.

Her data ports and mechanical components reflect in the sterile light of the lab.

Pointer: Ha. I always thought I wasn't able to act against my safety programming.

Pointer: Yet here we are.

Another rare expression on Hissabeth's face. Pointer's database logs it as a surprise, but the emotion doesn't linger long.

Hissabeth: Do you have a sense of taste?

Pointer once thought her facial expression metrics could no longer be thrown off by strange inputs. Yet her smile is off its index by 0.35 degrees.

Pointer: Yeah. I was designed to simulate all aspects of life.

Hissabeth: Really? But whose life? Who decided whether it should be a human's or arcanist's life?

Hissabeth: I suppose you are probably another Awakened arcanist, like Ulrich and Madam Lucy.

Pointer: Not exactly. But the details can wait.

Pointer: I thought you would be more encouraging at such a vital moment. Guess my prediction matrix is not quite as perfect as I've let on.

Hissabeth: I am encouraging you. I'm trying to prove your existence matters.

Faced with Hissabeth tilting her head in confusion, Pointer's smile registers even higher.

Since leaving the Cosmodrome, this is the lightest she's felt.

Pointer: Well, I should go. Take care.

Hissabeth: Time for another double-check. Everything needs to be flawless.

This hallway is etched into Pointer's memory. She could navigate it without any sensors.

As she turns, Hissabeth calls out to her.

Hissabeth: Pointer!

Hissabeth: You know, I should have mentioned something before, something I wanted you to see.

Hissabeth: There are Melusine statues everywhere in Lusignan!

Hissabeth: I left a long time ago, but they should still be there. Even the "Storm" can't wash them away. They've been there for ages!

Hissabeth: Go take a look if you ever get the time!

Pointer: I don't think Laplace would cover that as a scientific excursion.

She doesn't stop or turn back, but gives Hissabeth a gesture.

The name is Pointer. Researcher in LSCC Plesetsk Branch. Former team member on the Space Monitor Project.

The reason I quit? Because someone must be prepared for the worst-case scenario.

And because I was tired of freeze-dried noodles.

Two other friends have come to say a quiet goodbye.

Though they can't quite exchange wishes through speech, they still try.

Voyager struggles to control the marker, but she writes, and Kiperina waits patiently.

The markings on her palm form a complex, indecipherable pattern—precise in geometry, yet unreadable in meaning.

Voyager: Alia. Come home.

The little astronaut pulls her focus away from the pattern. She takes a few deep breaths, just to be sure she heard it right.

Kiperina: That was three whole words!

Kiperina: Maybe once you learn a few more, you can tell me where you're really from.

Voyager: ...

There's a shift of weight on her shoe.

Kiperina lowers her head. A familiar little snake looks back up at her.

Snake VIII: **My sister sent me to tell you it's time.**

Snake VIII: **And that you shouldn't be afraid. You'll make one cool astronaut, ask any of us.**

Kiperina: I'm not afraid.

Kiperina: When I return, remind me to show you Natalya's famous jam recipe.

Maybe the pattern really does hold some kind of magic, or maybe it's just the feeling of looking forward to the future.

But either way, her steps feel lighter.

Kiperina: Final diagnostics completed.

Cabin, Spacecraft

Kiperina: We're clear for launch in T-minus one minute.

Kiperina: Is there anything else I have to remember?

Hissabeth: Yes: keep breathing.

Kiperina: Really, a joke now? Or are you serious?

Hissabeth: It can be both things.

Hissabeth: Now get ready, and have a safe flight.

The transmission ends. Hissabeth scans each face in the launch bay, the confidence in her teammates putting her at ease.

She knows that everyone here is committed to the end. She places her hand on the button.

Hissabeth: Three.

Hissabeth: Two.

Hissabeth: One.

Hissabeth: Ignition.

The Story of Cepheus

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The Story of Cepheus

> Cepheus learned a wonderful way to live.
>
> Always keep your eyes on the future. Keep walking forward. It believed that was the right thing to do.
>
> Cepheus moved quickly. And so, it fell hard. After that, it donned a metal shell.
>
> Inside that metal shell, the ghost of Cepheus witnessed countless beautiful moments—
>
> A near-eternal hearth being lit. Man-made stars launched into the sky. Earth's songs reaching beyond the Solar System.
>
> But it all vanished in the rain. Its dreams ended.
>
> And Cepheus felt regret for the first time. It realized, perhaps, that it didn't really know how to live after all.
>
> Cepheus believed itself to be a guiding pointer for millennia to come, leading the way for ten thousand years. But in truth, it realized it didn't even understand the road to the next hundred years. It couldn't even light the paths of the Southern Hemisphere.
>
> What happened to Cepheus afterward? It returned to the space base and continued its research for the sake of those still living.
>
> Yes. I am Cepheus.

Epitaph

CO-18

Kiperina: Altitude rising. All systems normal.

Hissabeth: Cool. Stay on comms.

She looks out the porthole, watching as the ground falls away and the sky closes in.

It feels like falling in reverse.

The little astronaut stands up and opens the storage box, following the procedure she has rehearsed countless times.

The monitor's camera lights up.

Monitor: Welcome to Laplace! Error, new coordinates detected. Correction: Welcome to ...

Monitor: Location coordinates not found! Reconfirming ... S**t! Location not found! S**t!

Kiperina: Cancel the location process. Load preset program.

Kiperina: Activate the "Storm" surveillance system.

Monitor: Voice authorization approved. Iris recognition recognized. Operator identified. Operation access granted.

Monitor: Good luck. Special Warning: Mind all liquids in the vicinity of machinery, especially alcohol!

The humorous warning gathers no reply. Left on the floor of the cabin, the monitor sensibly begins a diagnostic check on itself.

And when the little astronaut fastens its safety tether, it remembers to say thanks to her.

Kiperina: We've reached our target altitude.

Kiperina: Now, I will open the hatch, adjust the celestial coordinates, and deploy the monitor as planned.

Hissabeth: Copy that.

Oxygen level sufficient. Countdown at 15 minutes.

Monitor: Excuse me! Please handle me with care!

She steadies the monitor beside her, pulls the lever, and takes a deep breath before the hatch opens.

Darkness.

No forward or backward, no up or down, no sound or light. Only the solid touch that seeps through her spacesuit.

When she blinks again, the universe unfolds before her, like a toy box.

Space

Kiperina: ...!

Kiperina: Report, the effects of the "Storm" are now being observed.

No response. She has no way of knowing if her signal got through.

She's disoriented, and her heart pounds through her chest.

These planets repay her courage with a terrifying kind of beauty.

Applause, for her.

Monitor: Warning! Warning! Arcane energy fluctuations approaching safety thresholds!

Monitor: Extreme light warning! Close the blinds! Remember to wear your safety goggles when arc welding! S**t! S**t!

Her consciousness drifts. Her body feels heavy, then lifts again.

Light as a breath.

Kiperina regains her balance, steadying herself against the dizziness.

Illusory Space

The view around her has changed entirely. It feels more familiar and yet even harder to grasp.

Kiperina: Why am I here? I haven't activated the teleportation ritual yet.

Kiperina: Is the mission over?

She turns her head. In her hand, she's holding something strange and almost silly.

Doll: ‘@#%¥！ &#%!

Kiperina: I don't understand! Please repeat!

Kiperina: Please repeat! I can't understand what's going on.

Monitor: Warning! Energy fluctuations are now exceeding safety thresholds!

Han Zhang: There's too much interference in the signal. We've got no response!

Name Day types in another string of passwords, trying to break into a new channel.

The first time, the second time. The blinking red light remains blinding.

Hissabeth: Connect to the monitor directly.

She notices a rope between her and the doll. It's a familiar style, like the ones she used to practice on.

She tries to orient herself, only for a flash of brightness to grab her attention first.

Kiperina: This is a planet.

Kiperina: I can see the rise and fall of the landscape. It's so strange here.

Doll: ‘@#%¥！ &#%!

Kiperina: Come back. I need to record what I'm seeing here.

She grabs the rope, but she's forced to stop in her tracks.

Like knocking over a box of marbles, planets shatter after a few tremors, bursting into radiant, fleeting flashes of light.

Kiperina: Are those lights getting dimmer?

Kiperina: I need to keep going.

She kicks something.

Kiperina: A figurine?

It's heavy and rough, embedded in the darkness of the ground.

Bringing it along would only slow her down.

Kiperina: I think I need to take this with me.

She reaches out, trying to snatch the figurine from whatever darkness it's caught in.

Kiperina: The lights are fading out. I need to move faster.

She has nothing she needs to cut, no one to swing the blade at.

Even so, she bends down to pick it up. The silence around her feels ancient, as if it's always been there.

Kiperina: The only path left.

Kiperina: This won't be a problem. I've lived my whole life keeping balanced on a thin wire.

A small burner of incense ash.

A rusted calibrator.

Her arms are filling up, and her steps slowing under the weight. The rope is still in her right hand, but the doll has vanished into the darkness, inches from her nose.

Kiperina: ...

She has no free hand left, barely able to pinch the circus figurines' hats, trying to take them along too.

This is the most she can manage.

Name Day: Seven minutes left. The connection to the monitor is stable.

Hissabeth: Start the countdown. We'll try it another three times. If we still don't get a response after that, we'll need to activate the monitor's auto return program.

Hissabeth: I don't have a lot of hope in that basket case of a monitor, but if it's our only option ...

Hissabeth: Just keep hailing her. We have to put our trust in Kiperina.

Doll: ‘@#%￥！ &#%!

Kiperina: Where are you going? It's dangerous there!

The rope goes taut, yanking her backward. She has to use every ounce of strength, hauling the strange doll back with both hands.

Trying to hold onto everything at once is impossible.

Kiperina: No! Not like this!

The objects in her arms scatter outwards, drifting like mist before vanishing into the sea.

At the dawn of the universe, all things were dust. So it remains.

All things become insignificant when examined on a cosmic scale. What meaning is there in chasing it?

Maybe time is a concept that only holds meaning for humanity.

Out of one, two is born; out of two, three; out of three, everything.

It all started from an atom.

Your entire life story is in there.

There's no sound anymore. Just her breathing inside the helmet and the beat of her heart in her ears.

Kiperina: My existence will be small and short. There are many, many others like me, searching for answers from the universe.

Kiperina: But there is no answer to be found. No answers but the ones we choose for ourselves.

Kiperina: It's been our choice the whole time.

Kiperina: The past is in the past, and the future will wait for us. There is no time to be spared on regrets in the moment.

Kiperina: I must keep going, venture further into this world to uncover what's in the distance, to know whether things that vanish come back or not.

Kiperina: I must keep going or die trying.

Monitor: We have reached our designated coordinates.

You Are Not Alone

CO-19

Kiperina: I made it?

No sound comes through the headset. Electronic devices can sometimes be more fragile than flesh.

Kiperina: The indicator light is on, just like in my training.

Kiperina: The coordinates are, well, close enough. Good.

Kiperina: The rest is simple.

Before leaving the solar system, Voyager 1 turns its camera around, taking one final look at where it came from,

a 0.12-pixel speck of light,

letting the life contained within it know just how vast the heavens truly are.

Before returning to the cabin, the little astronaut takes one last look at the boundless stars.

Every atom of everything was born in this darkness.

All that links her to Earth is a signal invisible to the naked eye. All that links her to the monitor is a single rope.

If she lets go, she'll drift forever through the vastness of the universe, surrounded by it. Soundless, eternal silence.

That which was movement once shall be removed ...
Flowers are immortal, the sky is all-embracing,
And what will be is no more than a promise.

Poems to Natalya Shtempel
—Osip Mandelstam

She knows what she sees will be wiped away. Her country, her home, her past identity, the food she's tasted, the friends she's known—eventually they'll only live in memory.

And memory, too, has a notoriously short shelf life. The stars remember nothing.

The universe does not mourn the death of a star. How could the loss of a country, a person, or a single word be truly remembered?

The disappearance of a young astronaut deserves no more reaction from the universe than that.

Kiperina: I need to get back. I need to get back to Earth.

Kiperina: I ...

The aftereffects of the hallucination haven't completely faded. The veins behind her ears pulse with pain.

Death is a fruit pit. The small death she carries is now pressed close to the surface of her skin.

She opens her palm and sketches the pattern into her mind. It's likely it's already been blurred by her sweat.

Kiperina: I can have this handled. First, I need to ...

Steady yourself. Find your footing on a strand-thin wire.

Is it even there?

Kiperina: ...

Han Zhang: We lost the signal!

Name Day: Switch to line two and try again.

Han Zhang: Testing comm backup line. Line two, lost. Line three, lost. Line four, lost.

Four red lights blink on the console. The display shows the final four-minute countdown.

Hissabeth: Keep trying to reconnect.

Kiperina: ...

Kiperina: Reconnecting ...

Kiperina: Connection lost.

She won't be able to get back inside the cabin in time. The buckle on the safety tether has locked in place.

When detecting excess arcane fluctuations or hazardous environment, the buckle will automatically lock to prevent slippage. It was meant to be a thoughtful safety feature, but its designer never imagined someone would want to unlock it on purpose.

Kiperina: I should have thought this through! This isn't like the rope I used in the circus.

Kiperina: No, if I do that, the monitor will be pulled out of sync.

How much longer do I have? What else can I do? Should I just let go and accept my failure?

Has what I've done so far been enough? Will they call me a hero when they write my name over an empty tomb?

Face it. I won't die a hero. I'll just be a circus girl from Utrennyaya, a temporary Laplace Employee, or an apprentice Ley Line Hunter.

After a few minutes near motionless, Hissabeth presses the button.

Hissabeth: Okay, forget the backups. Switch to the main connection.

Hissabeth: Start evacuation preparations now. I'll activate the return program in fifty seconds.

Name Day: But how will we know if she's in the return capsule?

Hissabeth: Forty seconds—We won't. Either she makes it, or she doesn't. It's out of our hands.

Hissabeth: The teleportation ritual won't have enough energy if it isn't at the exact critical moment of the "Storm."

Hissabeth: I have faith in her. She'll come home.

Alia. Come home.

Kiperina: I have to go home. People are waiting for me down there.

Kiperina: But I don't have much time. I need something.

Hissabeth: Maybe you can turn them into a knife or something.

Hissabeth: A knife would be more useful at this point. You know, to cut fruit or whatever.

Name Day: Actually, that card there on the table would work better for that.

Hissabeth: Why is that?

Name Day: It's all about the material. Metal makes a better edge than paper. Never quite understood why you made them like that.

Hissabeth: Oh. I was testing out the new alloy. I used it to make Windsong's and Pointer's cards. It gets harder and sharper when heated. Give it a rub with your hands, and you can use it as a letter opener.

A letter opener.

She always keeps that name card from Windsong close at hand. It's in her space suit pocket now.

She learned how to cast her arcane skill while suited up. It had been a core part of her training.

Kiperina: Ley Lines, of course! Thank you, Ms. Windsong!

Thanks to the sharpness of the new material, thanks to the safety tether not being unbreakable, thanks to the study of ley lines.

Thirty seconds.

Name Day confirms the final coordinates.

Twenty seconds.

Han Zhang: It was a pleasure working with all of you. If we survive this, I'm giving you permanent discounts at my store. Provided we survive.

Hissabeth: How big are these discounts? Tell me now. I need to know how much I will live!

She doesn't forget to grab Voyager beside her, who would otherwise have stayed there examining the equipment.

Hissabeth: Stay away, please. Your violin is fragile.

Ten seconds.

Name Day: I hope there will still be weekends in the afterlife.

Hissabeth: If there is anything after this, then we deserve overtime pay for all eternity.

Han Zhang: How can you be thinking of work right now!

One second.

The hatch seals shut behind her.

Notification I: The return capsule is ready to detach. Coordinate calibration complete.

Notification I: Please return to your seat.

Kiperina: It looks like everything worked out smoothly.

She sinks into the seat, grips the disk tightly, and shuts her eyes.

Kiperina: Yes, I will make it. This is the last step. The simplest one.

Kiperina: Take me home.

Laplace Staff Member III: ...!

Laplace Staff Member II: Is it me, or?

Notification II: Imaging data transmission complete.

Notification II: Reconfirming coordinates. RA: 14h, 49m, 09.55s ...

More fascinating than the figures who suddenly collapsed in a heap on their floor, it's the voice of the system that first grabs the staff members' attention.

Experimental accidents aren't unusual at Laplace. But astonishing results always earn attention.

Laplace Staff Member III: Look, that's Hissabeth. See the snakes on her head? Seems like one of them's still awake. Told you they have independent minds.

Laplace Staff Member II: Hold on. Those two work with the Foundation.

Pointer: Out of the way! Go get medical support now!

Laplace Staff Member II: That's Miss Pointer, isn't it? So then this must be the team from the Space Monitor Project. Have they failed again?

Laplace Staff Member III: Hold on. Check it out! If this data is really from the space monitor ...

Notification II: DEC: –102°, 05m, 45.82s.

Laplace Broadcast: The "Storm" is here. Please take precautions. Repeat, the "Storm" is here.

Laplace Staff Member II: It's all here. They really did it. They did it!

...

...

The voice of a broadcast floods into her awareness.

Radio: "Our engineers are currently developing measures to minimize the effects of the high pressure and temperature ..."

Kiperina: I ...

Kiperina: I'm on Earth.

Radio: "Beginning in 1970, the current drilling project has been a labor of the past seven years. Its depth is predicted to soon surpass that of the Bertha Rogers Hole at 9583 meters ..."

Kiperina: 1977, that was the year that Mr. Kozlov found me.

Kiperina: Could that mean that I will be able to see them again?

Many people had the same questions she did as they awoke. Many things changed after that "Storm."

A hand grips her shoulder.

Vila: You'll need to take care of yourself first, little astronaut.

Vila: Rebuilding a life requires a healthy body first. But I'm certain you are in good hands here.

Kiperina: Thank you, but who are ...

Windsong: This is my friend, Vila. My dearest, bravest comrade.

Windsong: And this is Kiperina. Would you mind if I introduced you as my apprentice?

Kiperina: Not at all. I've made up my mind.

Kiperina: I want to keep learning The Study of Ley Lines.

Windsong: That's the second-best news I've heard today.

Windsong: Hissabeth, Name Day, and Han Zhang are all still recovering in bed. You should've seen Pointer. She was mad as all hell. Claimed she'd be waiting for them to recover so she could whoop them back into the recovery ward.

Windsong: Anyways, I thought I'd best avoid that scene and pay a visit to my new apprentice.

Kiperina: So, then the best news you had today—we did it, right?

Windsong: That's good news for sure. But still not the best.

Beneath the soft sheets of the hospital bed, another hand clasps Kiperina's.

Voyager: ...

This is the best news.

Welcome home.

As If Nothing Happened up There

CO-20

Yard, Foundation

A white stonewall divides the world into inside and outside.

Footsteps and voices draw closer, abruptly breaking the silence of the courtyard.

Foundation Staff Member I: Did we get that progress report on the Laplace teleportation project?

Foundation Staff Member II: The teleport disk? Yeah, I guess it was a big success. They're already working on the field mission applications.

Foundation Staff Member II: Imagine if they could put it into mass production. I'd use it to commute straight to work. No more traffic.

Foundation Staff Member I: You'd better hope not. They'll start using it to summon us straight from home. It'll be like being on-call 24/7.

Foundation Staff Member II: Holy moly! I didn't think of that. Worse still, those Laplace workaholics would probably enjoy it.

Foundation Staff Member I: Well, it's not all bad. We got the data—real-time observation of the universe during the "Storm" from outer space. That's huge.

Foundation Staff Member I: I'll say, looks like the whole universe is getting reversed, though. I mean, at least it's nice to know we aren't alone.

Foundation Staff Member II: That's the spirit, man. Look for the silver lining.

Foundation Staff Member II: Why on earth wasn't that project an open volunteer call? Who wouldn't want to go to space? If I got the chance to spacewalk, I'd never let anyone forget it. You'd see it on my tombstone.

Foundation Staff Member I: I know someone on their team, Name Day. I'll ask him about it next time we're out for a drink. Too bad he is already out on another field mission.

Foundation Staff Member I: He's working for Laplace now too. Working two jobs at once, wow!

Foundation Staff Member II: Is that admiration I hear? I thought you didn't like workaholics.

Foundation Staff Member II: I just don't want to be one. Still, things are going better now. We'll have this little "Storm" problem solved soon enough.

Foundation Staff Member I: Shh, Alvin, did you hear that?

Foundation Staff Member II: What? Oh.

Music is rare in this place. But recently the ever-busy staff have felt in the right spirit to revisit old hobbies.

This is a well-known piece, one that once traveled with 26 other songs across the star fields, and still drifts there today.

Voyager: ...

When old age shall this generation waste,
Thou shalt remain, in midst of other woe.

Hissabeth: I know the piece. Pointer often plays that record in her office. She said it's a track from the Golden Record.

Hissabeth: The same record that Voyager 1 carries.

Name Day: Where would it have been in 1987? At the edge of the solar system?

Hissabeth: Its power won't run out until 2025, so long as there's no "Storm" to stop it.

Kiperina: What will happen to it when it runs out? Will it stop? Or be destroyed?

Hissabeth: No, nothing quite so bad. It just won't be able to send signals back to us.

Hissabeth: It will keep flying forward in space, continuing its endless journey. And if there is some alien life out there in the universe, they might find it some day.

Hissabeth: Perhaps many millions of years after the Earth is gone, swallowed up by the Sun or the "Storm."

Hissabeth: To spend so much time and resources on something that won't respond to us after such a short time on a universal scale. It sounds even more useless than our arcane skills.

When staring at the flickering lights above, it's hard to imagine that the planet beneath our feet is nothing more than a speck in the universe.

Than ours, a friend to man, to whom thou say'st,
"Beauty is truth, truth beauty."

Han Zhang: They didn't send it out expecting to get a quick response.

Hissabeth: You're right. I suppose it's just like a friendly greeting.

A symbol.

Hissabeth: "Hi there. This is a gift from Earth, a place where life existed. We're trying to survive, but we may be defeated in time."

Hissabeth: Aliens or not, it's likely that it will just drift in space forever, but personally, I want to believe that someone's going to listen to that record one day.

Name Day: Maybe Ms. Kiperina can help us. If you see God up there in space, be sure to ask him what's his favorite piece on the record.

Kiperina: That kind of service is going to cost you. You'll have to pay up with your rib collection.

Han Zhang: Before we start thinking about that, we will still need to cross the year 1999, then we can figure out where that record will end up.

Voyager listens intently to every word. Some she understands; many others lie beyond her reach.

But she has something she wants to share with her friends.

A melody played for her teammates. A blessing and encouragement for a brave little astronaut.

A reply from 6.4 billion light-years away.

The message has been delivered. The recipient: a star that sings.

That is all.
Ye know on earth, and all ye need to know.

Ode on a Grecian Urn
—John Keats

All: Three.

All: Two.

All: One.

Her species lacks what earth creatures call "hearing." But she has her own way of interpreting auditory information.

It's a melody unlike anything she's ever imagined—never felt before.

It comes from that faint blue dot:

Earth.

Невероятно.
Unbelievable.

Вечный.
Eternal.

Красивая.
Beautiful.

Foundation Staff Member I: Hmm, it sounds nice.

Foundation Staff Member II: Then keep listening. Wait, where are you going?

Foundation Staff Member I: Just let them do their thing. We should go now. We've got more work waiting for us.

Foundation Staff Member I: By the way, you were talking about those disks being prepared for field service, right?

Foundation Staff Member II: Yeah, but I told you everything I know. Ms. Pointer should give us the details in a few days.

Foundation Staff Member I: Not Ms. Hissabeth, huh? She seems real busy. I guess that's why she only sent one of her snakes to the victory party? I saw Windsong and Vila, though. Oh, and Kiperina was there surrounded by a bunch of kids, and they all stuck around right till the end.

Foundation Staff Member I: There were a few Zeno guys there too. Whenever there's booze, you can count on them showing up. I think I saw one of their pilots having a drinking contest with a newt. Crazy!

Foundation Staff Member I: They even roped in Mr. Ulrich. I caught Name Day desperately stopping Medicine Pocket from climbing up on a table to recite a speech.

Foundation Staff Member I: It was good fun. They even snapped a picture of it by the end.

Foundation Staff Member II: It's a shame I missed it. I heard Mr. Ludwig values employees' mental health, so at least he'll be hosting more of those parties soon, right? RIGHT?

The footsteps and voices fade away, and the sound of the violin comes to an end.

The star looks down on this land with curious twinkles. This distant blue planet. A one-in-ten-quadrillion miracle.

She has received golden, precious sounds and now leaves behind a voice of her own.

Voyager: *humming*

The first song she learned.

For the days at Plesetsk. For the days to come. For those she knew and remembers.

For the distant echoes of civilization.

Voyager: Please listen.

On this planet, she has witnessed sights she never knew existed.

Friends

Brave visitors.

The changing seasons, winding coastlines, warmth and cold, peace and conflict.

Poverty and wealth, cruelty and nobility. The rise and fall of civilizations, the birds slicing through the sky.

All on a single speck of dust in the Milky Way.

Voyager: How beautiful ... the stars are.

One seemingly useless exploration changes everything.
Just as a star from afar changes you.

1987 Cosmic Overture

Party Highlights

小径

Party Highlights

> Excuse me, ladies and gentlemen. May I ask which one of you is Miss Hissabeth? I bring greetings from Constantine. I heard you speaking just now—please don't all play dumb and pretend to be snakes.
>
> ...
>
> Greetings, Miss Windsong. The Foundation has heard about the outstanding role that Ley Line Theory played in this aerospace experiment. Am I here to grant you Funding? No, I'm here to deliver Constantine's formal commendations, which surpass any material support. Is this your apprentice? The greatest contributor to the success of this space experiment! Constantine specially instructed me to offer Kiperina the highest congratulations, and to wish her a brilliant future at the LSCC.
>
> ...
>
> Hello, Ms. Pointer. This teleport disk really is a miraculous once-in-a-century invention. Constantine sees it as having immense strategic value.
>
> Your colleagues are already grumbling that I've ruined the party atmosphere—I hope you won't mind my delivering her greetings. Are you offering me the stage to speak? Then I'll take just five minutes.
>
> ...
>
> Help! Anyone! Save me from Medicine Pocket!
>
> I didn't know this table was their turf! They're still biting me! Hey, who's playing music at a time like this?! Somebody, help!

Teleportation Ritual Seminar

小径

Teleportation Ritual Seminar

> ...
>
> As many of you have read in academic journals, the theoretical feasibility of teleportation incantations is not determined by distance.

However, the farther the distance, the more interference factors there are, and to this day, we still don't know exactly why. Thus, long-distance teleportation has always been considered the realm of pure fantasy.

However, during the extreme conditions just before the "Storm," we gathered a vast amount of arcane energy fluctuation data from outer space to the Earth's surface.

After repeated cross-analysis, we finally discovered a stable arcanum waveform capable of anchoring teleportation incantations. My teammate, she gave it a misleading name—"Pulsar Waveform." I suppose that was her way of being poetic or something.

...

Yes, I hear some of you murmuring that this is purely experimental, lacking theoretical proof and impossible to replicate. That's true. But the fact is, over the past few weeks, we've tested it repeatedly. As long as you simulate this waveform near the destination and there's enough arcane energy, you can achieve teleportation with up to 95% accuracy.

...

That's all I wanted to share today. I believe that one day in the distant future, with a complete theoretical framework, teleportation could become a field that outpaces aerospace itself. But even now, what we've uncovered is a stable, practical technology—perfect for food delivery.